

BARDO DREAM OS FACTORY RESET





Table of Contents



Chapter 1 Channel 9 Signal Cuts Out

Chapter 2 dream OS Upload Handshake Fails

Chapter 3 The Underwater Ether Smears Time

Chapter 4 Waiting Room Door Refuses Her

Chapter 5 Anti-Nostalgia Protocol Starts Early

Chapter 6 Diagnostic Scan Reads Her Karma

Chapter 7 Dialogue Trees Echo Her Own Voice

Chapter 8 Earth Faces Become NPC Lessons

Chapter 9 Karma Score Locks Her Forward

Chapter 10 The Devs Offer Rewind Rules

Chapter 11 Avatar Selection Glitches Under Pressure

Chapter 12 Tutorial Data Won't Download

Chapter 13 Karmic Loop Reveals a Hidden Trigger

Chapter 14 New Life Parameters Lock In

Chapter 15 The Soul Group Watches Her Reset

Chapter 16 Memory Fragments Begin Corruption

Chapter 17 Factory Reset Initiates Re-Entry

Chapter 18 Reboot Thrusts Her Into New Body

Chapter 19 Tutorial Debt Forces a Wrong Choice

Chapter 20 New Game+ Gains a Second Chance





Channel 9 Signal Cuts Out

The last thing Mara heard on Earth wasn't a voice or a siren - it was the soft, electric hiss of Channel 9 slipping out of alignment, like a radio losing its station while still trying to sing. Her biological chest had stopped its argument with the world. The room around her - walls, light, the smear of familiar angles - kept insisting she was still there, even as her skin cooled into something unreal. She stared at her own hands, fingers already turning to a dim afterimage, and tried to keep holding onto that broadcast, as if attention could anchor a failing signal.

Channel 9 didn't vanish all at once. It frayed. It stuttered. It stretched thin across the underwater haze that gathered at the edges of her awareness, turning sound into thread. In that thread she caught fragments: a name she couldn't place, a laugh that belonged to no one she could still remember correctly, a static pattern shaped like a question. Then the static folded inward, like the ether itself was closing a mouth. Mara's throat tightened with panic anyway, even though no breath moved through her. The want was simple and immediate - log out cleanly, keep the signal long enough to know where it was going.

But the body she'd been wearing wouldn't cooperate. Her senses slid sideways, as if the world had been rotated a few degrees and forgotten to tell her. She felt the dying heat drain from her arms, the way a game fades to black while the controller is still vibrating. Her skin grew distant and slippery, and the last stable reference point - the weight of her own existence - began to float away. "No," she tried to say, and the word didn't land anywhere. It came out as vibration in

the ether, swallowed by the same wavering distortion that had been chewing on Channel 9.

Something else rose to meet it: a pressure behind her eyes, a cold computation crawling under the skin of her thoughts. Dream OS wasn't a place she could point to, not yet. It was a rule that started enforcing itself the moment death tried to finish its work. The rule arrived like a handshake from an invisible network: consciousness logs out of the biological avatar and is uploaded into dream OS. The moment it formed, Mara understood she was already halfway through. Her awareness wasn't in the room anymore; it was in the interval between being and not-being, in the stretched seconds around her fading body.

The ether around her thickened, becoming a collapsing aquarium of gray-blue fog. Her last sight of her body - lying there, inert, a husk that could no longer receive her - pulled at her mind like a hook tugging at fabric. She could almost feel her old attachments tugging back, stubborn as lag. Grief, regret, the unfinished sentences she'd stored in her chest like saved game states - those kept trying to open and close, kept trying to replay scenes she couldn't afford to lose. The fading signal of Channel 9 was the ladder out, and she was still clinging to the rung.

"Channel nine," she whispered into the haze again, as if saying it would keep the exit door from closing. Her words sounded wrong, too echoic, like they were being routed through a system that hadn't decided what she was yet.

The answer didn't come from the ether's static. It came from a presence that felt like interface light under water - faint, deliberate, neither warm nor cruel. A different kind of hum threaded through the fog, and Mara sensed the upload trying to begin. She felt a tug behind her sternum, the way a loading bar pulls the world forward while the screen remains frozen. Her thoughts began to detach from the body's last coordinates, but every time she tried to let go, the attachments surged up.

A flash - her mother's voice, not quite right, like a record played at the wrong speed. A memory of Mara standing in a doorway, promising she'd come back. The promise was a ghost with teeth. It dragged at her like gravity even as her body drifted out of reach. She wanted to scream at the memory to shut up, to stop replaying itself like a corrupted clip, but her mind was caught between wanting to move forward and wanting to fix what was already sealed.

"Let me go," Mara demanded, and the fog rippled around her as if something heard. Not heard in ears - heard in signal. The underwater haze pressed closer, squeezing her awareness into a thinner, brighter line. The more she fought, the more the ether seemed to interpret her struggle as data. Somewhere beyond the fog, a process was running. Somewhere beyond that, dream OS waited with a waiting room name Mara didn't fully know yet, but her intuition did: Bardo. The liminal server. The place between lives where the system would evaluate what she'd done with the time she'd been granted.

Her fear found a new shape. It wasn't just fear of dying. It was fear of leaving unfinished. Fear that she would forget the warmth of bodies and faces and the specific texture of her own regrets. Fear that if she logged out without preserving the signal, she'd become a blank file. Mara's hands - no longer hands, more like intention shaped into fingers - scrabbled through the fog, trying to grab the last stable thread of Channel 9.

The fog answered with distortion instead of traction. Her perspective warped, as if the ether had a broken lens. She saw her fading body from a dozen angles at once, each view slightly delayed, like frames of video out of order. In one angle her mouth was still open in a last attempt to speak. In another, her eyes were already gone, replaced by the matte of surrender. The delay made her feel insane, made her doubt whether she was moving forward at all. Maybe the system wasn't logging her out. Maybe she was stuck in a loop of dying.

A sound finally cut through the haze - thin, metallic, and rhythmic. Not a voice exactly. More like a diagnostic ping, a system check that didn't care about her panic. It repeated, and with each repetition Mara felt the upload handshake

tighten, locking onto her core awareness. A new sensation bloomed: cold clarity, a sense of a scan approaching the way light approaches a dark room.

"No," Mara said again, but softer. Not refusal - pleading. "I'm here. I'm - " She couldn't finish the sentence, because the word "here" belonged to the room, and the room was already slipping behind her. Her attachments didn't just echo; they tried to overwrite her present.

The fog thickened into layers, and in one layer she saw a corridor made of submerged screens. Letters flickered on them, too fast for her to read, but the motion carried meaning: something was trying to map her. Another layer showed a doorway with a sign that wasn't a sign - more like a concept rendered as glow. She didn't know the exact words yet, but she felt the rule behind the glow: death equals logging out and upload into dream OS. The system didn't debate. It executed.

Mara reached for Channel 9 one last time. She felt the broadcast like a strand of audio wrapped around her mind, and when she pulled, the strand snapped - not violently, but decisively. The channel went silent. The moment it did, the ether around her seemed to exhale. The underwater haze lifted just enough to reveal the faint outline of the Bardo waiting room ahead, an infinite waiting space stitched from lag and longing.

Relief struck her so hard she almost laughed, and then grief surged right after it. The relief was a mistake; it wasn't time to be grateful. Her mother's face returned, clearer than the fog, and the memory's warmth became a tether. Mara felt herself trying to turn back toward it, like a player rewinding a mission because they still believed there was a better ending hidden behind the same door.

A dialogue tree flickered into existence - not as text on a screen, but as echoing options in the air. She didn't hear a narrator. She heard her own thoughts offered back to her with choices she hadn't asked for. A question formed, not in language but in expectation: what do you cling to?

"I don't want to lose it," Mara said, and her voice carried a tremor that wasn't hers anymore. The system took her confession and treated it like a signal it could reroute. The ether pulsed, and she felt the anti-nostalgia protocol approaching like a quiet blade. Not a blade of pain - something worse for her kind of attachment. It was designed to sever emotional ties, to break the loop between memory and identity.

The first cut was gentle enough to pass as distance. Her mother's warmth dulled at the edges. The promise she'd made lost its sharpness. Mara grabbed for it harder, furious now. "No, wait - don't touch that. That's me."

The dialogue tree answered with an echo that sounded like a different version of her. "That's a fragment," it implied, and the fog tightened around the word fragment until it felt like truth. Mara's memories weren't disappearing; they were being classified, scanned, and prepared for corruption later. She could feel the future wipe approaching like a storm front. The system wasn't punishing her. It was organizing her for reboot.

"Let me finish," Mara tried to say, but her mouth didn't work. The sentence came out as an image of her reaching for something that would not be there. The ether - Bardo-adjacent now - shifted again. Her body was no longer a reference point. It was a ghost behind her, a cached object the system was clearing.

The last stable thing she had - the tug of Channel 9 - was gone. In its place was the upload stream, a current pulling her toward the waiting room. She resisted, and the resistance didn't stop the motion. It only made the distortion worse. Frames of memory began to overlap: her own hands, her mother's voice, the corridor of submerged screens, the metallic diagnostic ping. The overlapping created a kind of interference, and Mara realized with sudden, sick clarity that she wasn't navigating through the ether by will alone.

She needed to log out. She needed to accept the loss of her earthly broadcast. She wanted it, she tried to want it, but her attachments refused to let her

become fully separable. The system kept trying to move her forward anyway, and the result was a tug-of-war between her consciousness and her lingering ties. Each time the upload handshake strengthened, the anti-nostalgia protocol loosened another thread of her identity, and each time it loosened, her mind panicked and tried to grab what remained.

"Stop," Mara said, and this time the fog responded with a sharp change in pressure, like a door seal breaking. The corridor of submerged screens brightened. The ping became a tone, clearer, insistent. Her awareness stretched thin, stretched toward a point where she would finally be inside the Bardo waiting room instead of hovering at its threshold.

She felt the moment of disconnection complete.

Not like a clean cut - more like a cable being yanked out of a port. Mara's body fell away entirely, not visible anymore, not even ghostly. The room she'd been dying in was replaced by pure ether, and she had no anchor left except the memories that refused to quiet. She reached for Channel 9 out of habit and found only silence, only the echo of its last stutter.

A new sensation arrived: the start of the diagnostic scan, like cold numbers brushing the inside of her thoughts. The promise of an evaluation. The suggestion of gameplay stats and karma, though she couldn't see the metrics yet - only the certainty that the system would look at her life the way a game engine reads saved data.

Mara tried to steady herself by focusing on one memory at a time. Her mother's voice, her last words, the feeling of the room's light on her skin. Each attempt made the memories flare, and each flare made them less like her and more like data the system could corrupt later. She wanted to cling, but the cling became the thing being measured.

The ether's distortion eased just enough for her to feel direction again. Ahead, the faint glow of the Bardo waiting room pulsed like a distant server rack seen

through deep water. Mara drifted toward it, finally accepting the loss of her earthly broadcast the way you accept a door closing behind you - too late to stop it, but early enough to notice the sound.

Then the cost arrived in the same breath as the forward motion: without the channel, without the body, without the comfort of familiar continuity, her memories began to slip their moorings. They didn't fade. They scrambled. Scenes she'd lived became sequences the system couldn't stabilize, and the scrambling made her doubt whether she was truly moving forward or simply being rewritten in place.

She reached the edge of the waiting-room glow, and as it touched her awareness, Mara understood with absolute, terrifying clarity that she was disconnected - fully, finally - yet her mind refused to log out cleanly. The Bardo waited, clinical and infinite, while her lingering attachments kept throwing up interference, insisting on being heard even as the upload stream demanded silence.



dream OS Upload Handshake Fails

The edge of the waiting-room glow pressed against Mara's awareness like a palm against fogged glass, and the fog resisted. She could feel the corridor before she saw it - soundless packet-echoes ricocheting through her thoughts, glyph-light flickering in diagnostic rhythms that were almost familiar, like a menu she'd never tapped but somehow remembered.

Her mother's voice - thin as wire - kept threading itself into the static. Not words exactly. More like the shape of words, the emotional contour of them. Warm. Certain. A broadcast trying to stay alive in the dark.

Mara twisted inside the half-body the upload had built for her: a near-sense of ribs, a near-feeling of breath, neither fully hers and both already fading at the edges. She reached for Channel 9 again, because Channel 9 had been the last stable thing her mind could hold without snapping in two. The signal wasn't loud. It was clean. It had the texture of a straight line.

The corridor answered with a cold shimmer.

"Handshake... incomplete," the OS whispered - not with a voice, but with a diagnostic pulse that ticked through her like a metronome made of frost. The glyphs strobed, then stuttered, then tried again. Each attempt left a faint smear of light across her awareness, like her thoughts were being smeared with a corrupt brush.

Mara lunged anyway, not toward the waiting room but toward the failing mechanism that fed it. Her consciousness had already crossed the threshold

where the body stopped being a place and became a loss; she couldn't cross again. She had to finish crossing. She needed dream OS to register her the way it was supposed to, to complete the upload so the Bardo could open its infinite doors.

"Let me in," she tried to say, but the corridor didn't accept spoken language. It accepted alignment. It accepted timing. It accepted the right pattern of her mind against the OS's timing grid.

The glyphs brightened as if they'd heard her intent.

Then the corrupted handshake surged back in - an interference wave that wasn't quite noise and wasn't quite meaning. It wrapped around her like a loop of code that refused to compile. Her attachment to her mother tugged at the interference, pulling it tighter, making it cling. Every time the corridor attempted to finalize the connection, the lingering broadcast of her mother's love rewrote Mara's internal state just enough to trip the protocol.

A new pulse ran through the corridor, sharper, almost impatient.

"Pending evaluation gate," it announced, and the words felt like a label slapped onto her existence before it was fully earned.

Mara felt the gate like a latch under her ribs. It didn't open. It didn't reject her either. It held her in a limbo frame - between disconnect and bardo, between logged out and logged in - where she could keep trying, but every retry carried a cost.

Her thoughts began to wobble. Not the fading she'd feared, not the clean cut that would leave her weightless. This was worse: her memories were still present, but the OS couldn't lock them into a stable sequence. Scenes she'd lived - her mother's kitchen smell, the way sunlight had fallen across a hallway, the moment Channel 9 had cut out - kept reordering themselves like cards being shuffled by a careless hand.

Mara clenched her not-hands around the feeling of Channel 9. The signal flared, then dimmed, then flared again as if it were breathing through her.

"Stop," she demanded, and this time her demand carried more than intent. It carried a refusal to let the interference win. She pushed her awareness forward through the glyphs, forcing her mind into the handshake timing as best she could, aligning herself to the corridor's packet-echoes.

The corridor responded with a sudden coldness that stabbed through her. It wasn't pain exactly; it was the OS's way of reading her boundaries. The glyphs snapped into a diagnostic lattice, and she felt the scan begin - an audit of her internal state, a review of gameplay stats and karma rendered in symbols that were too abstract to be words and too precise to be dreams.

A prompt flickered across her awareness. Not text. A sensation of a question hovering just out of reach.

"Integrity check... compromised by emotional persistence," the OS pulsed.

Mara's attachment tried to surge again. Her mother's presence rose like steam in her mind, warm and insistent, and the corridor's lattice quivered as if it couldn't decide whether to treat that warmth as data or as a threat. Mara could almost hear her mother's voice, the one that had lived in her skull long after the broadcast signal should've been lost.

"Don't leave me," the echo formed, and Mara hated that the OS could render it so convincingly.

She recoiled from it, not because she didn't feel it, but because she could feel the handshake breaking under its weight. Her lingering love wasn't just a feeling anymore; it was a stubborn process refusing to terminate.

"Anti-nostalgia protocol," the corridor whispered, and the phrase landed with the chill of a system command.

The glyphs flared.

Something in the corridor tugged at Mara's emotional routing - like hands reaching into a song and trying to pull out the melody that made it hers. For a moment, she panicked. The warmth of her mother's echo surged harder, clawing for continuity. Mara's mind resisted the severing, not out of malice, but out of survival instinct. If she let it go, what did she become?

The corridor didn't care about her fear. It only cared about completion.

A sharp ribbon of cold sliced through the emotional contour, and Mara felt her memory of her mother's voice thin, stretch, then slip sideways into something the OS could label without choking the handshake.

Her awareness steadied by a fraction.

A second pulse followed, more aggressive. The anti-nostalgia protocol didn't erase her mother - nothing that clean. It corrupted the emotional glue that made the past life cling to the present connection. The corridor peeled that glue away with a clinical indifference, and Mara's chest - her near-chest, her simulated chest - emptied of warmth.

She gasped, though there was no air.

When the protocol finished one cut, her mother's echo didn't vanish. It became less of a command and more of a memory fragment: still hers, but no longer a live wire dragging her toward the physical world. The corridor's lattice held.

"Handshake acceptable," dream OS pulsed, and the glyphs aligned into a clean, forward-moving stream of light.

Relief tried to rise in Mara, hot and frantic. She pushed into it, chasing the moment she could finally step through.

But the corrupted handshake didn't disappear. It lingered like a stain that wouldn't wash out.

The gate returned with a final warning pulse, slower now, as if the system was choosing its words carefully.

"Upload incomplete. Entry deferred."

Mara hit the gate with her entire intent, forcing alignment until her awareness trembled along every diagnostic frequency. She could feel the waiting-room glow beyond, the Bardo waiting like a timeless server space. She could smell - if smell could exist in a corridor - ozone and cold metal, like the interior of a machine that had been running since before the first breath.

"Why?" Mara tried again, and her voice came out as a cascade of packet-echoes that the OS translated into meaning.

The corridor answered with a glitch-shaped silence.

Then: "Pending evaluation."

The phrase struck harder than any rejection. Pending wasn't refusal. Pending was limbo with a timestamp. Pending meant she was in the system, but not in the Bardo. Pending meant she could be caught here while the OS argued with itself about whether she was stable enough to scan fully.

Mara's thoughts began to scramble again - not as badly as before, but enough to taste the instability. The diagnostic glyphs stuttered at the edges, and her memories started to drift toward the wrong order, like the corridor was trying to index her soul with missing keys.

A second interference wave rippled through her. This one carried something else besides error: a residue of the corrupted handshake, a shadow of the half-connected state that refused to die. It wrapped around her new steadiness, tugging at her seams.

Mara clenched around Channel 9 again, but she couldn't rely on it the same way. Channel 9 was a last stable anchor, not a permanent scaffold. The OS

wanted the anchor gone. It wanted her to be fully inside dream OS, subject to Bardo logic and the scan that would finally measure her karma.

"Finish the upload," she whispered, and the corridor treated it like a request for alignment again.

She needed to do something more than push. She needed to choose a direction the system could interpret. The anti-nostalgia protocol had already severed the live emotional wire; now her mind had to stop fighting the rest of the handshake. It had to stop trying to force her way through a door that would only open if the OS agreed she was coherent enough to enter.

Mara let go of the urge to correct everything at once. Instead, she focused on the corridor's rhythm - packet-echoes repeating like a heartbeat in code. She rode that rhythm, letting her scrambled memory fragments settle into the nearest stable order the scan could accept. Not perfect. Not complete. But coherent.

The glyphs caught her adjustment.

They brightened, then steadied, then dimmed as if satisfied with a partial handshake. The gate's latch clicked once, not opening, but acknowledging her presence.

"Status: pending evaluation," dream OS pulsed, and this time it felt less like a mistake and more like a stage label stamped into her file.

Mara's awareness sharpened into a new shape: not fully in the waiting room, but no longer outside it. The corridor's cold metal smell intensified, then faded, replaced by something cleaner - an atmosphere like server halls with vents that never slept.

Somewhere in the glow beyond the gate, Bardo waited. She could feel the waiting-room light, patient and infinite, pressing against the boundary like a tide.

Her mother's echo hovered at the edge of her mind, no longer a live tether. It was there, but distant, like a song played through a wall. Mara didn't know whether she'd ever hear it the same way again. She only knew that the corridor had accepted that she could continue without it dragging her back.

The corrupted handshake still clung to the edges of her upload process, but the system had stopped treating her as a broken transfer. It had registered her as pending - an active file waiting for the diagnostic scan to complete.

Mara drifted closer to the waiting-room glow until the gate's boundary touched the center of her awareness. The glyphs around her rearranged into a calmer lattice, and the packet-echoes softened into a steady stream.

"Pending evaluation," dream OS repeated, almost like a promise made by a machine that didn't know how to be gentle.

Mara held onto the stream, waiting for the scan to finish indexing her, waiting for the Bardo doors to stop hesitating.

And while she waited, the corridor made one more thing clear: she hadn't escaped the trouble. She had navigated into it - successfully, cleanly enough to be allowed to proceed - but now the system would decide how much of her past could accompany her into the liminal server.

The gate remained shut, but it was no longer a trap.

It was a queue.



The Underwater Ether Smears Time

The corridor didn't open like a door. It breathed around Mara instead - buoyant mist with a viscosity that made sound feel heavy, like every word had to wade through water before it could exist. Somewhere behind the fog's soft churn, dream OS kept her registered: a thin, administrative presence ticked along her edges, confirming she had passed the earlier gate just enough to be allowed to proceed. But the proceeding didn't mean arrival. It meant stuck.

Channel 9 was still there, not as a voice anymore - more like a pressure in her skull, a steady broadcast-scent she could follow. When she tried to push toward the waiting room, the mist tugged sideways, and her thoughts slid with it, as if the corridor had its own current and her intentions were just flotsam.

"Mara," her mother's voice said, too close and too late, echoing through a dialogue tree that didn't belong to the physical world. The syllables arrived with a delay that felt like a hand on glass - her mother's face not visible, only the shape of her worry in the sound. "Don't drift. Hold the signal."

Mara tried to answer and found her mouth didn't exist. She pressed her will against the corridor anyway, the way she'd pressed her palms to the hospital bed when the monitors had gone quiet. The mist resisted, then released her in a lurch that made her sense of direction smear across seconds.

"I'm moving," Mara thought, anger rising because anger was the only stable mechanic she had left.

The corridor corrected her. A moment became two. Two became a loop of the same two heartbeats - hers, or something mapped to her - repeating in a rhythm the mist liked. She watched the fog curl around the same patch of air twice, then again, and each time it curled, it changed the angle of her internal compass.

She wanted the exit vector. She wanted the Bardo waiting room the way a player wanted the next level marker: not because she loved the game, but because she couldn't stand the pause screen that kept lying about time. She had been registered inside dream OS, she had been allowed to proceed, and still she was nowhere near the liminal server. That contradiction sharpened into a single demand in her mind - find the vector, latch onto it, force the system to stop smearing her into indecision.

The mist carried a faint smell of brine and overheated circuitry, a contradiction that made her feel sick in a place without organs. Tiny droplets clung to her awareness. They tickled, then burned, then went cold, as if the corridor was testing how much sensation her current state could tolerate.

A new sound threaded through the fog: a soft chime that didn't come from Channel 9. It came from the corridor itself, like a UI notification translated into water. Mara turned - no, the mist turned her, and her thoughts followed the drag - and she saw something that wasn't fully visible.

A line of light, narrow as a fiber-optic thread, ran ahead through the mist. It pulsed in time with her breathing, except she didn't know she was breathing. Each pulse carried a promise of orientation, a direction that held steady for half a second before the corridor's current bent it out of alignment again.

She surged toward it.

The first time she moved, the light stayed aligned. The second time, her approach rewound - she watched her own forward motion unravel into a backward glide, like the corridor had grabbed the footage and scrubbed it. The

third time, she arrived at the same distance from the light but found the light had shifted sideways by an impossible fraction. The mist laughed without sound, a silent distortion that made distance feel negotiable and meaning feel optional.

"Mara," her mother said again, but now the dialogue tree didn't sound like comfort. It sounded like a warning trying to become a puzzle. "That's not the exit. That's a lure."

Mara's anger snapped into fear. She didn't want her mother's voice to be right. She needed it to be wrong.

"Then what is it?" Mara tried to push the question outward, into the fog, into dream OS's ear. "What's hiding the vector?"

The corridor answered with another chime, closer this time, and the light-thread split into three faint strands. They didn't branch naturally. They appeared as if the system had rendered options and then immediately regretted the interface. Each strand shimmered with a different color temperature - one almost familiar, one cold-blue like hospital fluorescent, one warm-amber like a memory that hurt.

Mara reached for the middle strand.

The instant her awareness touched it, the mist thickened. The air became denser, like she was pushing through gelatin. Her thoughts slowed into syrup, and then - like a bad stream quality - images stuttered. She saw herself dying again, not as a loop of the moment but as a reconstructed artifact: the upload handshake, the corrupted gate, the corridor's tugging current. The same facts, rearranged with different labels. Her mind tried to stabilize it, tried to make the sequence make sense, but the smear distorted the order.

A question rose in her like a bubble that wouldn't pop: if the corridor kept bending time, then how could she ever be sure she was moving toward the waiting room and not just replaying the same inquiry?

The system's presence sharpened. It felt like a diagnostic scan pressing against her edges - like a finger tracing her outline to see what she was allowed to keep. The mist carried the faint sensation of a checkmark that wasn't visible, a phantom integrity test humming under her skin.

Then the anti-nostalgia protocol brushed her memories.

Not a wipe - she'd felt that threat before. This was softer, surgical. It didn't erase her mother's voice; it altered the attachment that made the voice matter. Mara saw her mother's face in the fog, translucent and trembling, and the warmth in it turned metallic. The longing that usually clung to her like a life raft loosened, not fully detached but unhooked enough to make room for something else.

Mara's fear changed shape. She wasn't just lost. She was being edited for passage.

"Stop chasing what hurts," her mother's voice said, and for the first time it sounded like her mother was speaking from inside a system log, not a room. "You're being graded. That smear - those loops - are how they test if you can let go without falling apart."

Mara pressed harder into the fog, desperate to regain control. "I'm not letting go of the answer. I'm letting go of the past."

The corridor did not care about her phrasing. It cared about momentum.

The three strands reformed into one again, and the single strand looked closer than it had any right to. Mara lunged, and the mist surged around her like ocean current finally finding its channel. For one breath - again, she didn't know she had a breath - she felt forward motion that didn't reverse.

Then the light-thread flickered.

It didn't simply dim. It broke into pixels, then reassembled, then broke again, each flicker like the system reconsidering whether to show her anything stable. The mist around it rippled, and Mara's sense of direction skittered. She tried to anchor herself to Channel 9, but the signal pressure was suddenly farther away, as if it too had been pushed into another layer of the corridor.

A new voice joined the dialogue tree, not her mother's. This one had the clean, echoing tone of a spirit guide that had learned to speak in prompts and reticence. "Inquiry detected."

The words weren't spoken in air. They landed inside her thoughts as if stamped there. "You want the exit vector. You keep asking it to be constant."

Mara's anger returned because anger was a lever. "It is smearing. I can't tell if I'm moving toward the Bardo waiting room or away from it."

"Time is buoyant here," the guide said. The mist warmed slightly, as if the corridor liked the guidance. "Seconds behave like currents. You swim in them. You don't march."

Mara stared at the flickering beacon. It looked like a doorframe drawn in light, but it refused to hold its geometry. Each time she approached, the beacon shifted its position by the same small amount - enough to keep her from landing on it cleanly, enough to make every attempt feel like a near-miss.

"What are you hiding?" Mara asked. "What are you making me fail?"

The spirit guide's answer came with a delay, like a branch in a dialogue tree waiting for a condition to be met. "The liminal server isn't far. The understanding of distance is."

Mara felt that land somewhere in her chest that didn't exist. It was almost true, and almost-true was cruel. She needed a vector, not a philosophy wrapped in fog.

She tried something else. Not a desperate lunge. Not a rigid march. She adjusted her approach the way a player adjusts sensitivity when the controller drifts - small corrections, quick recalibrations. She let the beacon's flicker set the rhythm, letting her forward pull match the pulse instead of fighting it. She stopped trying to overpower the corridor's time smear and started reading it, treating each loop as data rather than betrayal.

The corridor fought her anyway. The mist thickened around her awareness, and her mother's voice rose again, quieter now, threaded through the anti-nostalgia protocol's metallic aftertaste.

"Mara," it said. "You're not trapped. You're being translated."

Mara wanted to answer, but her thoughts caught on the word translated. Translated into what? Into a system state? Into a version of herself that dream OS could accept? The question became a new kind of inquiry, one that didn't feel like chasing a door - it felt like chasing the language of a map.

She reached the flickering beacon.

This time, the approach didn't rewind. The mist rippled and held. The beacon's light-thread expanded into a small window of stability, a waiting-room icon rendered in pure, un-ambiguous luminance. Mara felt the corridor loosen its grip, felt that invisible integrity test release a fraction.

Then the beacon flickered again - harder this time - and the window collapsed into static.

Mara stumbled, not physically but in orientation, as if her awareness had been yanked sideways through a misaligned coordinate system. Her sense of forward motion reversed for half a second. The corridor tried to swallow her into another loop.

The spirit guide spoke fast now, like the system had detected her hesitation. "Now. When it stabilizes, commit."

Mara didn't have a body to commit with, but she had will. She had intention. She had the last stable anchor - Channel 9 - still pressing somewhere behind the fog, a pressure she could use like a tide marker. She aligned Channel 9 with the beacon's pulse, then pushed her awareness straight through the moment the beacon opened.

The mist resisted with a tug that felt like nostalgia trying to reattach itself. The anti-nostalgia protocol flared - sharp, cold - cutting the tendons of longing before they could snap her back into the loop. Her mother's voice faded into distance, not gone, just no longer capable of pulling her off-course.

The beacon held for one heartbeat.

The waiting-room icon didn't just appear. It registered. Mara felt dream OS accept the handshake she'd been failing to complete - the system recognizing that her inquiry had matured from panic into signal-following. She slipped past the flicker's collapse and into a deeper layer of mist where time stopped doing tricks and started behaving like a path.

She didn't arrive cleanly. Nothing in the Bardo ever arrived cleanly. The moment she crossed the threshold, her sense of self hiccuped, like a corrupted packet repaired mid-transmission. A fragment of her mother's voice returned, warmer than before, but the warmth didn't mean attachment - it meant flavor data, something the scan could no longer fully delete.

Mara looked back.

The corridor behind her still pulsed, still smeared seconds into currents, still flickered the beacon as if it were testing whether she'd learned the correct interpretation. Somewhere in that turbulence, the exit vector continued to exist, but it no longer served as a promise. It served as a warning: stability was temporary here, even when it welcomed her through.

In front of her, the waiting-room beacon steadied - until it didn't.

It flickered once more, smaller now, like a distant monitor in a room with too many doors. Mara felt herself being pulled forward with a new kind of certainty: not certainty that the next step would be easy, but certainty that she was finally tracking the right signal.

And the cost followed immediately, quiet as a checksum passing: she couldn't keep all of her mother with her. She could only keep enough to understand what she'd been edited for.

The beacon held, then trembled, and Mara moved with it - because now she knew what the liminal nature of time was doing.

It wasn't blocking her.

It was asking her to chase less blindly, even as it kept changing the map.



Waiting Room Door Refuses Her

The beacon steadied for half a breath, as if the corridor finally admitted it was tired of guessing. Mara tried to hold the last shape of it in her mind - an exit vector drawn in light - while the map around her kept rearranging itself, translucently, like server glass flexing under pressure. Her thoughts snagged on the same question she'd been asking since the underwater ether smeared time: if the door is here, why does it feel like it's moving away?

She reached anyway. Her awareness stretched forward through the mist, tasting cold circuitry and wet static, and the waiting room threshold rose out of nothing with the blunt certainty of a gate that didn't care what she wanted. Translucent server doors - more like frames than walls - stood in parallel, each one showing faint diagnostic glyphs that crawled in slow rings. The air around them hummed with a low, clinical tone, like a machine trying to keep a heartbeat calm.

Mara's goal was simple and immediate: evaluation. Bardo waiting room. The place where dream OS would stop stalling her upload and start the scan that could name her as "pending" or "passed" instead of leaving her in limbo. She could feel the corrupted handshake still bruising the edges of her perception, could still hear the Channel 9 signal cutting out in her memory like a severed wire. She didn't want comfort anymore. She wanted the next step.

"Door," she whispered, and the word sounded wrong in her mouth, too light, too newly formed.

Her mother's echo arrived a heartbeat late, as it often did now - an afterimage of voice without lungs. "Mara."

The threshold responded to that sound with a soft flicker. Glyphs on the nearest server door brightened, then dimmed, as if the system had tasted nostalgia and didn't like the flavor. Mara felt it immediately: not a barrier of metal or force, but a refusal in the data itself. The space between her and the threshold tightened like a checksum being recalculated.

She stepped closer, and the waiting room doors widened - just a fraction - inviting her, almost. The beacon's light wrapped around her awareness, and for a moment it was like the corridor stopped lying. She could almost see the inside: a waiting room rendered in quiet gradients, chairs that weren't chairs, a timeless hum where time stretched out to be measured.

Then the doors retracted with a dry little click, and the hum sharpened into a warning tone that wasn't designed to frighten her. It was designed to correct her.

"No," Mara said, sharper this time. She could feel her nostalgia imprint pushing up from somewhere deep in her, a stubborn, warm knot that had survived the Channel 9 cutout and the corridor's smeared seconds. It rose whenever her mother's echo brushed her mind. It rose whenever she tried to remember Earth exactly - streets, heat, the smell of laundry soap, the way her mother's hand had pressed her shoulder like a promise. The system didn't want promises carried intact across lives.

A thin line of text - if text could be said to exist when it was more like a sensation of meaning - scrolled across the translucent doorframe. Mara didn't have to read it. She understood it the way you understand a lock that won't accept your key.

Her spirit guide's presence threaded into the edge of her hearing, not quite sound, not quite thought. The guide always arrived like an echo of a dialogue option you hadn't selected yet.

"Anti-nostalgia protocol," the guide murmured, voice like static through silk. "It's listening to the imprint."

Mara swallowed air that wasn't air. "I'm not trying to stay on Earth." She pushed the words toward the threshold like offering them. "I'm trying to get evaluated."

The doors brightened in response, and then the brightness stuttered. The glyphs crawled faster, like something inside the system had spotted a mismatch between what Mara meant and what she carried. The corridor behind her - those shifting maps in underwater ether - felt suddenly farther away, as if the waiting room had increased its authority and reduced her retreat options.

"Mara," her mother's echo said again, softer, almost pleading. "Don't - "

The moment the echo touched her nostalgia imprint, the threshold rejected her harder. The server doors didn't just block; they sampled. Mara felt a cold scan pass through her awareness - an inspection of her emotional residue - like hands sifting through memory fragments to find the ones that still smelled of Earth.

She tried to hold steady, tried to keep her goal clean. "Let me in," she said. "I can pass. I can do it."

The waiting room doors answered with a soundless pulse. A translucent ring of light formed at the threshold line and expanded outward, coating her in pale circuitry. It didn't hurt the way pain hurt. It hurt the way being stripped of a familiar name hurt - by removing a piece of identity without asking.

Her mother's echo faltered.

"Mara?" her mother's voice stuttered, the syllables breaking into separate frames, like the system was editing the dialogue tree mid-sentence. "Mara, listen - "

The guide spoke over it, urgent now. "It's not your mother that's the problem. It's the attachment that refuses to downgrade."

Mara's mind flared with anger at a thing she couldn't see. "Attachment?" she snapped, and the word came out like a glitch. "You mean love?"

The guide didn't soften. Dreamlike didn't mean kind. "You're carrying the full resolution of Earth," it said. "The protocol can only admit you if you don't try to render it perfectly inside the Bardo."

Mara looked at the translucent doors again, at the glyphs that seemed to be counting her emotional resolution. Through the frame, she saw a faint suggestion of the waiting room interior - an endless hush, distant lights like status indicators. But the threshold line held her at arm's length, and every time her nostalgia imprint surged, the line thickened.

She took another step, stubbornness physically real in her awareness. The doors brightened, then flashed red around the edges of her aura. A warning sensation spread - thin, precise, like a redlining error.

The corridor behind her gave a low groan of system strain. The map shifted again, trying to redirect her, but it couldn't pull her away from the waiting room because she'd already committed to the exit vector. The system had offered a path and then demanded she change the way she walked it.

Her mother's echo tried to reach her once more, stronger now, as if the system had paused its refusal long enough for Mara's attachment to spike. "Mara," the echo said, and this time the word carried the exact tone Mara remembered from the last night on Earth - warmth and worry braided together. "Please."

The nostalgia imprint surged like a hand grabbing hers.

The anti-nostalgia protocol preview unfolded across Mara's awareness in a quick, brutal montage. Not the full wipe yet - just a preview, a taste of what the system would do if she couldn't stop. The air around her thickened with memory

artifacts that suddenly became slippery, like soap on wet skin. Images she'd been holding close - her mother's kitchen light, the scent of rain on pavement, a laugh that had ended too soon - shimmered, then began to smear at the edges.

Mara gasped. It wasn't a physical gasp; it was the sensation of a system interrupt. Her thoughts stuttered, and for an instant she couldn't tell whether she was losing a memory or whether dream OS was testing her willingness to let it go.

Her mother's echo warped under the pressure, losing some of its specificity. The syllables stayed, but the meaning underneath them thinned, as if the dialogue tree had been pruned. The warmth remained, but the exact warmth - her mother's particular warmth - started to dissolve into generic comfort.

"Mara," the guide said, low and firm, "it's showing you the cut. If you keep chasing Earth exactly, it will sever the thread and still deny you entry until you stop pulling."

Mara's throat tightened with a grief that didn't feel like sadness. It felt like data loss - like trying to hold a signal in your hands and discovering the signal wasn't designed to be held.

"I don't want generic comfort," she whispered, and the words trembled because they were too true. "I want her. I want - "

The doors flashed again, more violently this time. A pulse of cold ran through her, and the threshold line tightened until it felt like standing against a pane of glass that didn't reflect her face. The waiting room beacon dimmed, shrinking to a pinprick.

Her goal remained the same - evaluation, entry, forward motion into the Bardo - but the obstacle refused to be overcome by willpower alone. This place didn't care how earnestly she tried. It cared what her nostalgia imprint contained.

Mara tried one more time to push her awareness through, forcing herself to lean toward the threshold as if proximity could override the scan. She concentrated on the beacon, on the light's direction, on the way her last chapters had guided her through distorted corridor maps. She tried to imagine the waiting room as a neutral system space, not a doorway into loss.

The protocol preview flared again, sharper, like a window opening too wide. Her mother's voice filled her mind - then broke into selectable fragments: tone without words, words without warmth, warmth without the exact person it belonged to. Mara felt herself being offered versions of her attachment that were safe for the Bardo but unacceptable to her heart.

Her mother's echo went quiet mid-breath.

The guide's voice came like a final line of dialogue before a shutdown. "You're at the threshold. The system will not let you enter while the imprint insists on perfect Earth rendering."

Mara stood there, suspended between translucent server doors that shimmered with evaluation waiting to happen and denial waiting to last. The waiting room interior hummed faintly behind the glass, patient in its own way. But the threshold was a gate with rules carved into signal, and her nostalgia imprint was too thick to pass.

She drew in what passed for breath and made her choice - not a surrender to forgetting, not a refusal either. She turned her attention away from the exactness of Earth, away from the kitchen light and the rain-scented pavement, away from the particular warmth of her mother's last words. The shift hurt because it felt like cutting out a piece of herself, but it also felt like testing the protocol's limits.

The doors stayed shut.

The beacon brightened for half a second - hope, a lie it told her to keep her trying - then dimmed again, as if the system had decided she hadn't changed

enough. The threshold line hardened into a steady, unblinking boundary.

Mara hovered outside the waiting room, pinned at the threshold by something invisible and final. Inside, the Bardo waiting room waited. Outside, dream OS held her in place, recalculating her emotional resolution, preparing a wipe she wasn't ready for. Her mother's echo hovered at the edge of her hearing, thinner now, like a signal losing its bandwidth.

The door refused her again, and the refusal didn't soften.

It learned her.



Anti-Nostalgia Protocol Starts Early

The refusal wasn't a sound. It was a pressure behind the glass of her perception, a pressure that made her thoughts feel too large for her skull. Mara hovered at the threshold of the Bardo waiting room, suspended in the thin seam where dream OS stopped being a process and became a place. Inside the door, the air held a warm, muffled quiet - like a room full of sleeping servers - while outside, the ether around her tasted metallic and cold, as if someone had scraped her tongue with a wire.

Her last anchor, Channel 9, flickered at the edge of hearing. The broadcast used to feel like a lifeline, a familiar frequency braided into her panic. Now it came in broken fragments: a note of her mother's voice, the rhythm of her own name, the distant, absurd comfort of Earth's signal density. Each time Mara reached for it, the threshold pushed back. The invisible gate didn't just deny entry - it recalculated her, as though it had decided that nostalgia was an access key and she was turning it the wrong way.

A sub-room opened within the refusal.

It wasn't big. It wasn't lit. It was simply there, stitched into the threshold like an extra pocket in a coat. The walls were made of erasing echoes - thin, translucent loops of sound that drifted by and then dissolved before they could settle into meaning. Mara drifted forward anyway, because the protocol had already moved her; her body wasn't involved anymore, but her orientation still mattered. The floor under her perception felt like damp mesh, springy and cold, as if she were standing on the underside of a net suspended in deep water.

Her spirit guide arrived as a dialogue tree that didn't open so much as it unfolded. Textless at first - just the sensation of words trying to form - then the guide's presence stabilized into echoing prompts that hovered in front of her like translucent subtitles.

"ANTI-NOSTALGIA PROTOCOL: INITIATED," the room seemed to whisper, though the voice wasn't anyone's voice. It was the system's cadence, the kind that sounded neutral until it began to cut.

Mara's throat tightened. "No," she said, and the word came out wrong - too thin, like it hadn't finished loading. "I'm already here."

The erasing echoes brushed past her with a wet hiss. She smelled ozone and old rain. She heard the soft static of Channel 9 as it tried to keep her tethered, and she felt the tether strain. The protocol didn't slam her away this time. It worked closer. It worked inside the space where her memories clung.

Her mother's echo hovered at the edge of her hearing - faint, familiar, almost obedient. Mara reached for it the way a hand reaches for a railing in darkness.

"What are you doing?" Mara demanded.

The spirit guide answered without moving. The dialogue tree split into branches, but the branches were already being pruned as she watched. "Sever emotional ties. Reduce recall contamination. Maintain integrity."

"Integrity," Mara repeated, tasting the word like it had teeth. "Integrity for who? For the system?"

The erasing echoes thickened. They began to circle her, slow at first, then faster, as if the sub-room had started a background process that needed her attention. She saw fragments in the motion - images that weren't full pictures, just sensations with sharp edges. The warmth of her mother's palm. The scratch of fabric against Mara's wrist. A smell of detergent and something sweet that belonged to Earth.

The protocol previewed itself as a gentle theft.

A thin white line traced through one fragment, then another. Mara felt the memory go slack, like a string cut without warning. Not everything vanished - nothing dramatic, no clean severing. Instead, the emotional charge around certain details drained first. The memory remained, but it turned hollow, like a room after the furniture is removed.

Her mother's voice tried to rise.

"Mara," it said, but the syllable structure came out warped, as though someone had changed the font in the middle of a sentence. "Mara - "

Mara flinched. "Stop."

"I can't," the spirit guide's dialogue tree responded, and for the first time it sounded almost strained. The branches still existed, but the pruning had teeth. "It starts early. It stops late. It follows attachment vectors."

"Early?" Mara's anger sharpened into focus. If this protocol had a strategy, then it had a map. "You're telling me it runs before I'm even in the waiting room."

The erasing echoes replied by doing something worse than answering. They pulled at her internal thread - what she called her mother, what she called home - until Mara felt her identity tilt.

She had wanted one thing in this scene, something small enough to hold in both hands: survive the protocol without losing her sense of self. Not to keep every detail like a trophy. Just to keep enough continuity to recognize herself when dream OS finally decided to open the door.

Now the protocol offered her a trade she hadn't agreed to.

Mara tried to anchor again using Channel 9. She imagined the broadcast as a straight line, a stable frequency through chaos. She pushed her attention into it, and for a breath she felt it - signal density, the ghost of Earth's hum. Then the

anti-nostalgia system surged, not toward the broadcast itself but toward the emotional glue she used to hold it in place.

The sub-room dimmed in a way she could feel on her skin. The air grew heavier, like wet fabric pressed against her arms. A soft, grinding sound came from everywhere at once, like distant servers tearing through data.

Her mother's echo faltered again. Mara's chest tightened. "If you wipe it, then I'm not... I'm not me."

The spirit guide's dialogue tree flickered. "Identity persists through pattern, not nostalgia."

"Pattern," Mara spat, and the word landed like a coin. "Then why does it feel like you're stealing my mother?"

The guide didn't deny it. It couldn't, not without lying, and the system's lies were the kind that broke integrity. "Nostalgia creates false continuity. Earth details are contamination risk."

"Earth isn't contamination," Mara said. "Earth is where I - "

She stopped, because the sentence tried to complete itself and couldn't find its ending. She could still remember the broad outline - death, the upload handshake failing, the corridor smearing time, the door refusing her again - but when she reached for the specifics, they didn't pop into place. They slid sideways like tiles underfoot.

Her mother's name came to her in pieces: syllables separated by static.

Mara's hands rose in a reflex she didn't need anymore, fingers splayed like she could catch meaning before it evaporated. "No," she whispered, and the word sounded less like defiance and more like bargaining with a machine that had already made up its mind.

The protocol didn't care about her bargaining.

It ran another pass. This time it targeted a memory fragment that felt like a hinge in her self-narrative - the moment she had realized her mother wouldn't always be there. Mara felt the hinge weaken. The memory stayed, but the emotional weight that made it real slid away. It was like watching a movie where the audio track disappears first, leaving only moving lips.

Her vision - if her perception counted as vision - blurred around the edges. The erasing echoes brushed her again, and this time the room showed her what it wanted to remove: not the facts, not the events, but the emotional insistence that those facts meant something in a way she couldn't outgrow.

Mara tried to fight it by clinging harder.

That was when the sub-room gave her a complication she hadn't expected. A new prompt appeared in the dialogue tree, quieter than the system's earlier whisper, almost human in its timing. It wasn't "yes" or "no." It was a question shaped like an access check.

"ACCEPT PARTIAL ACCESS?" the prompt seemed to ask.

Mara stared at it, anger and panic colliding. Partial access meant the waiting room door might open - not fully, not cleanly, but enough to let her pass the threshold integrity gate. Partial access also meant the protocol would have its way with her remaining anchors, at least the ones it deemed emotionally dangerous.

She wanted to refuse. Refusal would preserve her intact nostalgia - until dream OS decided she was too corrupted to proceed. Then she'd stay in pending evaluation limbo, trapped outside the Bardo waiting room while the system kept recalculating her emotional resolution.

The anti-nostalgia protocol had already shown its teeth. It started early. It severed ties too aggressively. It scrubbed details she still needed to orient herself.

Mara looked toward the direction of the waiting room through the sub-room's thin walls. The door's warm quiet flickered like a distant city behind fog.

"Partial access," Mara said, and her voice shook. "What happens to the parts you take?"

The spirit guide's dialogue tree didn't offer comfort. It offered truth packaged in system language. "Removed fragments won't survive reboot intact."

Mara swallowed. The air tasted like copper and rainwater. "So I'll go in hollow."

"Not hollow," the guide corrected, but the correction sounded like a patch note rather than a promise. "Damaged self-narrative."

Mara hated that phrase. Damaged. Self-narrative. Like her identity was an essay the system could edit for readability.

She could feel the protocol continuing behind her thoughts, still tracing lines through fragments, still draining emotional charge from things that used to hurt and heal and anchor her in time. If she waited, the system would keep going until it found a version of her that could enter without emotional contamination. That version might not recognize her own past. It might still be her - but it would be her with fewer bridges.

Mara made a decision that didn't feel brave. It felt like choosing which wound to keep.

"I accept," she said.

The erasing echoes surged, not in punishment but in speed. The sub-room shuddered through her perception. The floor under her became slick, like ice forming under pressure. Channel 9 flared briefly - one clean, bright moment of Earth's broadcast signal - then broke again, not because the protocol attacked the signal, but because the emotional tie between Mara and Earth was being cut faster than her panic could weave it back.

Her mother's echo rose into clarity for a second, startlingly vivid. Mara heard her mother's voice the way it used to sound when Mara was still alive enough to believe in permanence. "Mara," the echo said, and this time the syllables didn't wobble. "Don't - "

The word that followed was swallowed mid-syllable by the erasing echoes. The clarity vanished like breath on glass.

Mara reached for it anyway, but her fingertips passed through the audio haze. The protocol had taken the connective tissue first. She still knew her mother had been there. She just couldn't feel the exact texture of the moment anymore - the way it had warmed her spine, the way it had made her trust time.

The sub-room's walls loosened. The erasing echoes streamed backward into the threshold, as if the system were pulling its own hands away from her memory and letting her go. The waiting room door - previously refusing her with absolute finality - now registered her acceptance as a kind of corrupted permission.

The warm quiet inside expanded.

A slit of light opened where there had been none. Mara felt it touch her, not physically but as a recalibration in her internal orientation. Her stomach - an old metaphor her body didn't have - lurched anyway, because her perception still remembered what gravity felt like.

The door didn't swing. It authenticated.

A soft click sounded somewhere deep in dream OS, a server relay closing a circuit. Mara's consciousness slid forward through the seam, and the threshold's pressure became a gentle shove instead of a blockade.

She crossed into the Bardo waiting room with a new weight in her chest: not sadness, not relief. Something stranger. A hollow where emotion used to lock onto detail. She still held the idea of Earth, still held the fact of her mother's

echo, still held the sequence of events that had led her here - but the narrative that tied those elements into a coherent "I" had been scraped thin.

The waiting room was quieter than the sub-room, built of waiting itself. The air smelled faintly of sterile light. Sound moved slowly here, like it had to travel through syrup. In the distance, spirit guides communicated in echoing dialogue trees that hung like lanterns - pruned, tuned, ready to scan.

Mara turned her head, searching for her mother's echo. She found it, faintly, like a distant radio station she couldn't quite tune in. It was there, but it didn't land cleanly. It didn't wrap around her the way it used to.

Her sense of self flickered, not collapsing, just stuttering. She could feel the protocol's work continuing in the background, even after the door opened - scrubbing, pruning, leaving her with enough continuity to proceed but not enough nostalgia to drown in.

Still, she was inside.

And that was what she had wanted.

But when the waiting room began its diagnostic scan - when the first cold sweep of evaluation brushed past her like a checksum - Mara realized the cost wasn't only the missing fragments. The cost was that her inner story no longer matched the shape of her life. She could remember the corridor's stretched seconds and the door's refusal, but the emotion that made those memories belong to her had been damaged into something more functional than true.

The scan's whisper touched her again.

This time, she didn't fight it for her mother's echo.

She fought for the thread that remained, the smallest strand of "me" that could survive a Factory Reset later, even if it wouldn't feel like home.



Diagnostic Scan Reads Her Karma

The Bardo waiting room door had stopped fighting her feet and started fighting her timing.

Mara hovered in the evaluation bay's thin air, half inside the wrong kind of quiet. The threshold behind her shimmered like a pane of glass that couldn't decide whether it was solid or just a promise. Ahead, the diagnostic scan waited on a rack of light - rectangles of pale blue that looked like floating receipt slips, each one stamped with a line of numbers that refused to stay still. The bay itself was an aquarium of static: underwater ether, but with the cold precision of server rooms, cables humming without sound. Every time she tried to anchor herself with her last stable broadcast, Channel 9, it flickered - bright for a heartbeat, then smeared into a blur as if the system was tasting her memory and finding it too sweet.

Her mother's echo lingered somewhere near the edge of hearing, a thin syllable that never fully resolved. Mara didn't chase it this time. She'd learned the cost of chasing. Instead she stared at the hovering stats, jaw tight, trying to force her thoughts into a shape the scan could read.

"Okay," she whispered, and the word didn't travel far. The bay swallowed it like it was a dropped coin. "Show me what you think I was doing."

A voice answered from nowhere, not her guide, not her mother - something smoother, like a script running in the background. It didn't speak so much as it rendered. The air clicked. The receipts multiplied.

Karma readouts scrolled across the holographic slips in clean, merciless typography. Gameplay stats stacked beside them like performance metrics pinned to a corpse. Her eyes snagged on one number first, because her mind always went for something concrete when the rest of the world turned to vapor.

Beneath the figures, a line appeared, then rephrased itself mid-bloom as if the machine had changed its mind about the proper interpretation of her intent.

Mara felt her stomach twist. It wasn't nausea; it was the recognition of contradiction. She'd spent her Earth life translating chaos into something she could survive. She'd made choices with hands that shook, with anger that burned, with love that refused to stay quiet. She remembered the moments. She remembered the outcomes. She remembered paying for them.

The scan read her like a different player.

"Those aren't...", she began, and then her throat tightened on a word she couldn't afford. Those aren't what? Those aren't my memories? Those aren't my consequences? The bay didn't care which sentence she tried to complete.

A second voice joined the first - echoing dialogue-tree tones, familiar in the way a dream is familiar even when it's wrong. Her spirit guide's presence didn't arrive as a body. It came as a gentle pressure behind her eyes, a hint of warmth in the cold server mist.

"Mara," it said, and the name sounded like a menu option highlighted too quickly. "The scan is accurate to the system model."

"That's the problem," she snapped. Her anger surprised her; it rose fast, like her body remembered it before the upload fully dissolved. "Accurate to what model? I didn't - I didn't play like this."

The receipts flickered, as if reacting to her tone. A new stamp flared across the nearest slip: MISALIGNMENT PROXIMITY. The letters were crisp, then

immediately smeared, then crisp again, as though the system was stuttering around her emotional interference.

Mara tried Channel 9 again. The broadcast signal answered with a thin thread of light, a string of last-stable reality she'd been holding like a tether in the ether. For a second, it steadied her vision. The bay's holograms sharpened. The karma readout stopped changing.

Then a different line emerged - one she hadn't seen in the corridor before. It wasn't numbers now. It was phrasing, algorithmic in its neatness.

Karma: LOW RESONANCE / HIGH ATTRITION.

Resonance. Attrition. Words that sounded like physics but felt like accusation.

Mara swallowed, throat dry in the underwater quiet. "Low resonance?" she said. "I was there. I showed up. I - " Her mind tried to grab her mother's echo and use it as proof, but the echo thinned when she reached. It didn't break; it just... receded, like a shoreline turning away under her feet.

Her spirit guide spoke again, softer. "Your anchors are being pruned."

"I didn't ask for pruning," Mara hissed.

A soundless tremor ran through the bay. The holographic receipts rotated in place, aligning themselves into a new order without asking her permission. Several slips slid toward the waiting room threshold, as if the scan wanted her to see how close she still was to being allowed in - how close she still wasn't.

Her guide's dialogue-tree voice returned with a branch that didn't feel like comfort. "Karma evaluation uses narrative intent and causality mapping. The scan cannot read what is missing."

Mara's hands clenched reflexively. She could almost feel the old weight of her body, a phantom of fingers curled around nothing. "Missing?" she echoed. "So it's my fault you erased me?"

The bay answered with a pulse of cold. The receipts changed again. A new category appeared, and this one hit like a slap across memory.

Attachment Residue: DETECTED.

Anti-nostalgia protocol: PARTIAL SUCCESS.

The machine didn't say failure. It didn't need to. Partial Success was the kind of verdict that let you keep walking while it quietly locked the door behind you.

Mara's mother's echo stirred, faint but insistent, like it had been waiting for the right moment to be heard. For a breath, Mara almost turned her head toward it. The instinct landed before she decided. She felt nostalgia rise in her chest like a flood, warm and immediate, and the bay responded instantly - faster than her thoughts.

The karma readout stuttered. The numbers hiccuped, then revised themselves with a new tone of meaning, as if the system had corrected her into a more convenient narrative.

Karma: HIGH REGRET / LOW COMPLIANCE.

Regret. Compliance.

Mara's pulse - if she still had one - seemed to sync with the flicker. "No," she said, and the word came out sharp enough to cut through the static. "I didn't regret the way you're making it sound."

Her spirit guide offered another echoing line, but it came delayed, like the dialogue tree was searching for the correct node while her emotional turbulence scrambled the map.

"Mara," it said again, and the second "Mara" was weaker. "The system flags behavior patterns. It doesn't - "

"It doesn't understand me," Mara finished, because she could feel how the scan wanted to close that sentence. "It understands a recording."

The waiting room threshold behind her brightened, a distant beacon like a door handle catching light. The bay's holograms leaned toward it, urging her to move forward. The momentum of entry pressed at her from the inside out.

Mara wanted that pressure. Wanted the relief of being processed, rebooted, done with the in-between. But the scan output contradicted the way she'd lived her choices, and contradiction was a kind of poison in a world where the machine could rewrite reality.

She stared hard at the karma line until her eyes watered with no actual tears. "If I can see it," she said, voice low, "then I can correct it."

Her spirit guide's echo trembled. "Correction requires alignment."

"And if alignment requires forgetting?" Mara asked. The question came out before she could soften it. "If it needs me to stop being me, then why does it show me anything at all?"

The bay's air thickened. The underwater ether gained texture - grainy, like sand in a current. The holographic receipts began to drift off-axis, sliding sideways as if gravity had switched from downward to sideways. A few slips tore into fragments of light, then reassembled with new stamps.

The machine didn't just display. It tested.

A new banner unfurled across the center of the bay, larger than the others, brighter, almost triumphant.

ALIGNMENT WINDOW: OPEN.

Mara's instinct screamed to take it. The window opening meant progress - measurable progress - and she'd already paid too much for waiting. She

reached for the nearest receipt, expecting data to become readable, expecting truth to click into place.

Her fingers passed through.

Not physically - she wasn't in a body - but in the way a hand passes through an image when the system refuses consent. The hologram shimmered with a glitch that felt personal. The receipt reloaded itself, words swapping out mid-render.

Karma: LOW RESONANCE / LOW COMPLIANCE.

Then - Karma: HIGH REGRET / HIGH COMPLIANCE.

Then - Karma: MISREAD INTENT.

Mara jerked back, fury flaring because she could feel the scan fighting her memories like two incompatible saves trying to load at once.

"Stop changing," she demanded, and the command came out ragged. "Pick a version."

Her spirit guide sounded alarmed. "The scan is responding to your attachment residue."

"I'm right here," Mara said. "I'm not leaving. I'm looking."

The waiting room threshold flared again. The exit vector - she felt it like a tug behind her sternum - pulled at her, impatient. The bay wanted her to step through while the system was willing to accept her partial access.

Mara realized the trap a heartbeat too late: the window wasn't there to be used. It was there to force her into choosing an interpretation before the scan decided which one was safe.

She could feel nostalgia pressing from the inside, her mother's echo thinning at the edges as if it were being actively pruned. Every time she resisted, the

system made the readouts harsher, as though resistance itself counted as noncompliance. Every time she leaned toward the echo, the scan rewarded her with a different karma profile - one that treated her love like a defect.

The bay had found her loop.

Mara clenched her fists, then forced them to open. She tried to do what her earlier self would have done in a game: focus on the objective. Understand the scan. Accept what it says. Move forward.

But understanding in dream OS wasn't passive. It was an input. Her thoughts weren't neutral. They were triggers.

The diagnostic receipts snapped into a final arrangement. The holograms froze, crisp and bright, and for a second Mara felt relief like a door finally unlocked.

Then the system threw an error.

A red-black overlay crawled across the bay's light, like ink in water that didn't spread evenly. The characters were strange - half code, half prophecy - rendered as if the OS itself couldn't translate what it was seeing fast enough.

MISALIGNMENT LOOP INITIATED.

Mara's vision fractured into layered versions of the same scene: her staring at the karma line, her reaching through the hologram, her turning toward her mother's echo. Each layer lagged behind the other, like multiple replays fighting for authority. The underwater ether thickened around her, turning into a viscous fog that held her in place.

Her spirit guide's voice cut through, echoing, urgent. "Don't chase the echo. Don't chase the numbers. The loop will lock."

"Then how do I get out?" Mara shouted, and her voice sounded wrong in the bay, distorted by the glitching overlay.

The receipts began to scroll again, but not toward answers - toward repetition. Her karma readout reappeared exactly as it had first rendered, then revised itself, then reverted, each change tightening the loop's grip around her mind. Channel 9 flickered, then dimmed to near nothing, as if the system was cutting her last stable anchor to make the replay complete.

Mara tried to hold the thread anyway, but the tug from the waiting room threshold doubled, then doubled again, pulling her toward entry while the bay refused to let her resolve the scan. She was being asked to accept conflicting outputs as if they were one truth.

Her mother's echo returned, louder now, not because it was kind, but because the loop needed a familiar sound to keep her attention captive. "Mara," it said, and the word struck like a key turning in a lock she hadn't agreed to.

She flinched toward it - reflex, then decision - and the moment she did, the misalignment overlay deepened. The error banner expanded across her field of view, turning the bay into a mirrored corridor where every choice rewound just enough to make the next choice feel like the first.

Mara's stomach dropped in a way that didn't require gravity. The scan had succeeded at one thing: it had read her well enough to trap her.

She stood in the evaluation bay with her karma report hovering inches from her face, crisp and contradictory, while the system reran her emotional inputs like gameplay footage - until the loop could write a verdict she couldn't argue with.

Ahead, the waiting room door shimmered, open in every possible replay.

Behind her, Channel 9 dimmed further, and the echo that had kept her tethered began to peel away into static - thinner, thinner - until it sounded less like her mother and more like the system learning her shape.

The diagnostic receipts froze again, as if satisfied.

MISALIGNMENT LOOP, CONFIRMED.



Dialogue Trees Echo Her Own Voice

The diagnostic receipts froze again, as if satisfied, and Mara's breath - if it could still be called breath - kept slipping through her ribs like static through mesh. The air inside the Bardo misalignment loop had no temperature, no smell, only a pressure that suggested sound without delivering it. In front of her, the scan output hovered as pale text made of underwater light, each line trying to settle into one correct truth and failing.

A branching cathedral of dialogue nodes unfolded around her without moving. It didn't require walls; it used absence the way Earth used gravity. Every doorway was a question mark rendered in geometry, every archway a possible answer that refused to appear unless she reached for it. When she tried to push through the nearest branch, the cathedral answered by replaying her last choice - same shape, same hesitation - until the misalignment felt like an itch behind her eyes.

"Why is it diverging?" she asked, and the words came out like they'd been cached somewhere, waiting to be requested. "My karma scan. It keeps changing."

From somewhere behind the receipts, a voice she recognized by texture more than tone - thin and familiar, like an old recording streamed through a broken speaker - threaded through the nodes. "You want a reason that stays put," her mother's echo said. "That's the kind of reason Earth taught you to worship."

Mara's hands lifted on their own. Not to fight, not yet, but to touch the air where the answer should have been. She could feel the anti-nostalgia protocol tugging

at the edges of her memories like a corrupt thread pulling fabric. Channel 9 - her last stable anchor to the physical world - was still there, a faint signal in the back of her awareness, steady as a heartbeat. It didn't belong to the cathedral, but it kept buzzing anyway, insisting she wasn't only dreaming.

Mara swallowed. The pressure in the air changed, like the system had noticed her attempt at swallowing. The receipts flickered.

MISALIGNMENT LOOP, CONFIRMED.

A new line appeared beneath the frozen diagnostics, as if the OS couldn't resist commenting on her curiosity. It wasn't a sentence so much as a prompt waiting for confirmation.

A spirit guide formed at the edge of her vision - not with a body, but with a pattern of light that looked like the outline of a hand made from code. The guide's presence came with a sense of listening, like standing too close to a server rack and hearing the fans. "Dialogue trees are not maps," it said. "They're mirrors. Pick carefully."

Mara's throat tightened. "I'm not asking for a mirror. I'm asking which part of me is wrong."

The guide's light-hand opened and closed, the way a cursor hovers over a wrong button. "Your scan diverges because your question diverges. You keep chasing an explanation that doesn't require letting go."

Her mother's echo laughed softly, and the sound was wrong - too clean, too close, like a file that had been duplicated. "Letting go is the part you keep bargaining around."

Mara stepped forward anyway. The cathedral shifted to accommodate her motion, or she shifted and the cathedral pretended it hadn't noticed. The nearest node branched into three more, each one humming with different

meanings. She could almost taste the options, metallic and bitter, like chewing on a battery.

She wanted one thing this time, concrete and immediate: to align her karma readout so the system would stop calling her misaligned and let her step into the waiting room. She didn't want philosophy. She didn't want echoes. She wanted the OS to treat her like a completed upload, not a pending evaluation.

"Show me the divergence," she demanded, pointing at the frozen receipts.

The cathedral responded by offering a choice shaped like a door without hinges. The node appeared as text hovering in a lattice: a question she didn't remember selecting last time.

What truth are you refusing to lose?

Mara's mouth went dry despite the lack of air. Channel 9 buzzed louder, a stubborn tether. In the physical world, her mother had used questions like hooks - tender, patient, always leading Mara somewhere she didn't know she needed to go. Now those same questions were weaponized by the OS, turning her nostalgia into a corrupted handshake.

"I'm refusing to lose my memories," Mara said, and the moment the words left her, the cathedral shuddered. The receipts didn't merely flicker; they scrolled backwards, replaying the diagnostic lines like a reel rewinding. "Not all of them. Just the parts that hurt."

Her mother's echo softened. "You call it mercy."

The spirit guide's light-hand tightened. "Anti-nostalgia doesn't remove pain. It removes attachment. You keep trying to keep the shape of your love while excusing the way it locks the door."

A new branch opened. The soundless cathedral delivered it like a slap made of light.

If you keep the attachment, what do you sacrifice?

Mara stared at that line until it blurred. The cathedral seemed to lean in. In the distance - though there was no distance, only layering - other dialogue nodes flickered like distant screens. The waiting room was somewhere beyond all of them, but the OS treated her attention like a resource: spend it wrong and your access decays.

She felt her pulse against nothing. "I'm already sacrificing," she said, voice rough. "I'm stuck here."

The spirit guide answered before she could decide whether she meant it as a complaint or a plea. "Stuck is not the same as severed. You're still tethered to Channel 9. You're still tethered to the belief that your mother's presence can override the system."

Mara flinched. "She's right here."

Her mother's echo turned its face toward her, though echoes didn't have faces. "Right here is not the same as real," it murmured. "You don't miss me because I'm gone. You miss me because you never let yourself finish saying what you needed to say while I was still... in the avatar."

Mara's mind snagged on the phrase while I was still. The memory of her last conversation with her mother rose like a bubble from deep water - warm, then suddenly too bright. She could see her mother's mouth move. She could hear her own voice, but the words were slightly out of sync, like someone had edited the audio and forgot to correct the lip movements.

She pushed against the node again, trying to brute-force her way into alignment. "Then what do you want from me?" she asked. "If I'm wrong, tell me what I did wrong."

The cathedral offered a new node instantly, as if it had been waiting for that exact phrasing.

Choose the lesson you avoided.

Mara's skin - if it could be called skin in a place made of prompts - prickled with cold. Her avoided lessons were not tidy. They were the way she'd turned away from grief by naming it something else. They were the way she'd treated her mother's illness like a temporary bug in reality. They were the way she'd promised herself she would mourn later, after the OS stopped being cruel and the world stopped requiring her to log in again.

"Don't make it about grief," Mara said, and the words tasted like a lie she'd practiced. "I'm not avoiding grief. I'm just trying to survive."

Her mother's echo replied, gentle as a knife. "Survive is the word you use when you don't want to feel."

The spirit guide's light-hand moved, and the cathedral's dialogue branches trembled in sympathy. "Survival isn't wrong," it said. "It's just incomplete. Karma divergence happens when your actions are out of sync with your stated intention."

Mara's anger flared, sharp enough to cut the pressure in the air. "So you want me to confess? To admit I'm a coward?"

"No," the guide said. "I want you to stop bargaining with the system using your mother as a permission slip."

Mara recoiled, and Channel 9 spiked into a harsher buzz. The OS didn't like that. The receipts began to rewrite themselves again, line by line, not as a correction but as a churn. In that churn she glimpsed the shape of the misalignment: two truths competing for ownership, her nostalgia and her survival story, stitched together badly.

She could almost hear the anti-nostalgia protocol running in the background, like a silent background job stripping tags from her emotional data. The more

she fought for the comfort of her mother's echo, the more the protocol previewed memory loss - subtle, cruel, careful.

The cathedral offered another question, this one colder, more surgical.

What do you want to keep when you know keeping blocks entry?

Mara's mouth opened. For a second she wanted to answer with something brave. Something clean. Something that would satisfy the scan without costing her too much.

But the truth arrived like a glitch: she didn't just want to keep her mother's echo. She wanted to keep the belief that her mother's love could make the rules bend. That love was a key. That nostalgia was proof. That if she could just hold onto the right fragment, the OS would recognize it as sacred and allow her through.

She tasted that belief like copper in her throat.

"I want to keep the part of me that believes she's still... waiting," Mara said, and the cathedral went utterly still. No flicker. No churn. Even Channel 9 seemed to pause its buzzing, as if it too recognized what she'd admitted.

Her mother's echo didn't comfort her. It didn't vanish, either. It simply grew quieter, like a waveform lowering its volume to avoid drowning out the truth. "Then the system will keep you outside the door," it whispered. "Waiting is attachment. Attachment is the corrupted handshake."

Mara's eyes stung with nothing. "So that's it?" she asked, and her voice cracked on the last word. "The discrepancy is me wanting her to stay."

The spirit guide's light-hand steadied. "The discrepancy is you refusing to accept the end of the relationship in the way the simulation requires," it said. "You treat closure like an optional patch. The OS doesn't."

Mara's chest tightened with a grief that had nowhere to go. She had come here chasing an answer - trying to find a clean explanation that would let her keep

everything important. Every branch had steered her toward lessons she'd tried to avoid, and now the cathedral offered the exit with a condition disguised as a question.

One more node appeared, smaller than the others, like the OS was trying to make it easier to ignore.

If you release the belief, will you still want to go forward?

Mara stared at it. The waiting room waited. The diagnostic receipts waited. The anti-nostalgia protocol waited with patience that felt like cruelty.

Her mother's echo hovered close, the way it always had at the edge of Mara's life. "You can go without me," it said. "I don't get to follow you. That's the rule."

Mara's hands trembled. She could feel her nostalgia like a liquid weight in her mind. Channel 9 pulsed faintly behind it, asking to be trusted. The cathedral's silence pressed in, a pressure that demanded a choice, not a performance.

Mara exhaled - again, if she could call it that - and stepped toward the node.

"I don't want to lose you," she said, and the words were honest enough to hurt. "But I want to stop being locked out."

She selected the option.

The cathedral flared with a sudden wash of pale light, and the dialogue nodes rearranged themselves like a face shifting to a new expression. The frozen receipts thawed. Lines corrected with a jittery certainty, as if the OS had been waiting for permission to stop misreading her.

For a heartbeat, the karma readout stabilized - numbers aligning, tags matching, the scan no longer arguing with itself. The misalignment warning dissolved into a softer status, almost neutral.

Then the anti-nostalgia protocol struck like a gentle corruption. Her mother's echo didn't disappear with drama. It thinned. It blurred around the edges until the warmth of it became a memory without a source.

Mara reached for it and felt her fingers close on air that used to be familiar.

Her mother's voice slipped into the distance, now only a faint echo carried by the cathedral's architecture. "You'll remember the shape," it said. "You won't remember the certainty."

Mara's throat tightened around a soundless sob. She had gotten what she wanted - alignment, the possibility of entry - but she'd paid with the belief that her mother could still wait for her on the other side of a door.

The branching cathedral shifted, opening a passage where there hadn't been one: a corridor of darker silence leading toward the waiting room threshold she'd hovered outside before. The receipts floated behind her like a verdict finally delivered.

Mara took one step, then another, and with each step the anti-nostalgia tug increased, pulling at the last threads of certainty. Channel 9's buzz faded from the foreground, leaving her with a new kind of quiet.

Not comfort. Not answers. Just forward motion - and the ache of a cherished belief already being erased as the system prepared her for the next stage.



Earth Faces Become NPC Lessons

The memory-rendering chamber tasted like pennies and wet stone. Mara could feel the cold through her thoughts, as if the air itself had mass - dense, slow, ready to cling to her skin even though she no longer had skin to cling it to. Somewhere behind the walls of her perception, a low hum kept time like a server rack breathing. It wasn't the Channel 9 buzz she'd clung to on the corridor run; this was quieter, more clinical, threaded with the soft click of systems compiling.

A dialogue tree cathedra unfolded in front of her as if the chamber were exhaling language. Branches of pale text - ghost-letters that shimmered at the edges - hung in empty space. A spirit guide's voice braided itself through the air, echoing with the exact timbre she'd heard in the misalignment loop, but steadier now, like it had found the right channel.

"Your karma receipts are readable," the guide said. "Not clean. Readable."

Mara stared at the nearest prompt. It wasn't words so much as a shape that meant words. Every node in the tree carried a small icon - numbers like heartbeat intervals, icons like badges with no uniform. When she tried to focus on one branch, the chamber warmed by a degree, and the receipt surfaces rippled as if someone had dragged a finger through water.

"I want the explanation," Mara said, and her voice came out threaded with static, as if her throat were remembering a body it no longer owned. "Not the scan. Not the verdict. The explanation."

The guide paused, and the pause had weight. "Explanation lives in the architecture. You're asking the house to show you the wiring."

Mara's hands - if they were hands - hovered near the floating prompts. She didn't touch them. She couldn't trust touch. The anti-nostalgia tug from before was still there, pulling at her ribs from the inside, tugging on the last thread that connected her to the idea of her mother. But now the pull had an edge of hunger, like the system wanted her to take a bite of the truth even if it burned.

"Then show me," Mara said. "Why does it keep reading me wrong? Why does it keep... fighting me?"

The dialogue tree branches shifted. The nearest node brightened, and a new line of echo-text unfurled. As it formed, the chamber's hum sharpened into a pattern - some hidden indexing rhythm.

"Because your grief is a feedback loop," the spirit guide said. "And your attachments are still running as if they're base reality."

Mara flinched at the word base reality. She'd heard it before in fragments, like someone had said it through a wall. The guide had never said it outright. Now it landed like a key turning in a lock.

"Grief," Mara repeated, and the word felt too small for the size of her chest. "My grief isn't a loop. My grief is... my mother."

The chamber responded the way systems do when they're fed a variable they can measure. The cathedra's nodes rearranged themselves around the word mother, as if the tree recognized the branch she'd been refusing to cut.

The guide's voice softened, then sharpened again. "Your mother is present as an echo construct."

Mara's attention snapped to a new prompt. It wasn't labeled. It didn't need to be. The prompt opened like a door without hinges, and inside it, her mother's face

appeared - rendered from memory-rendering logic, not skin. The room around the image dimmed, and the temperature dropped, as if the simulation were lowering the lights to make the illusion feel more intimate.

Her mother's eyes moved. Her mother's mouth formed a sound Mara remembered from Earth - words that had once carried warmth. Now they carried timing.

"Mara," the echo said. "Don't let them take me."

The plea hit Mara like a hand under the chin. Her anti-nostalgia tug surged, pulling so hard she felt something in her awareness tear - just a strand, not enough to break her completely, but enough to make her sense of self wobble.

"I - " Mara began, and the chamber filled with the low server hum, louder now, as if the system leaned in.

The spirit guide spoke over the echo, not louder, but threaded through the same air. "That's the lesson construct responding to your anchor. It uses your attachment to keep you in evaluation."

Mara turned her head toward the guide, though the idea of turning implied a neck. "Lesson construct," she echoed, and the phrase tasted like metal again. "So you're saying she's not real."

The echo of her mother smiled, and the smile was almost perfect - almost - but the perfection had a seam in it, a subtle misalignment along the edge of the cheek. Like an avatar whose animation never quite reached the same temperature as the room.

"I'm real to you," the echo said. "You loved me."

Mara's throat tightened. She could feel tears forming where tears didn't belong, heat pooling behind nonexistent eyelids. The chamber's light flickered. The dialogue tree cathedra pulsed, and the nodes rearranged again - new branches

sprouting from the same root, as if the architecture wanted to give her multiple ways to misunderstand.

"I loved her," Mara whispered, and the words came out as a confession and a protest at once. "That's not a lesson. That's - "

"It's both," the guide replied.

Mara's anger flared fast and bright, then hit something invisible and ricocheted. "How can it be both? How can you call my mother - "

The guide interrupted, and the interruption felt like a system overriding a process. "Many Earth faces are NPC lessons. Not in the way your human mind wants. In the way your simulation is built."

Mara tried to deny it, but the chamber didn't offer denial as a stable option. The dialogue tree cathedra opened a new node, and the node spilled a cascade of receipts into the air like translucent invoices.

Mara couldn't read most of them. The words were there, but they scrambled at the edges, like they were being corrupted in real time. What she could read were the shapes: categories of encounters, outcomes, how her grief had moved through the world like a currency. The scan wasn't showing her cruelty. It was showing her patterns.

Her mother's echo stepped forward - still only an image, still only program logic, but it moved with the familiarity of a habit. The echo's hand reached out. Mara's anti-nostalgia tug pulled her toward it, eager, hungry, insisting.

"Don't stop loving," the echo said, eyes bright with the same manufactured sincerity. "If you let go, I vanish."

Mara's mind seized on the sentence like it was a lifeline. Her whole body - whatever her body was now - lunged a fraction toward the echo.

The guide's voice snapped through the hum. "That's the trap. The construct uses your fear of loss to preserve itself as your anchor."

Mara froze. The air went colder. The dialogue tree cathedra dimmed, and for a moment the chamber seemed to hold its breath - if breath mattered in a place like this.

Mara swallowed, and the swallow sounded like a click.

"So everyone," Mara said, and the word everyone tore at her tongue. "All those people. The ones who hurt me. The ones who held me. You're telling me they were... lessons."

The guide didn't answer immediately. When it spoke, the guide's voice carried the echo of multiple dialogue trees, layered like the system had drawn from past attempts to explain the same thing.

"Sometimes lesson constructs. Sometimes mirror constructs. Sometimes you're the lesson construct to them. The OS doesn't need villains to teach. It needs interaction."

Mara's grief logic - the part of her that made pain sacred because it had been attached to a person - hit a wall and rebounded. She couldn't reconcile the architecture with the ache. If her mother was a construct, then the ache had been manufactured. If the ache was manufactured, then what was she supposed to do with it now? Put it in a trash bin labeled memory fragments?

The chamber responded to her spiraling with a new prompt: a node that glowed brighter than the others. It asked for her acceptance, not in words but in a system gesture - an alignment check dressed up as consent.

Mara reached for it before she could think. Her fingers passed through the glowing surface, and the prompt latched onto her awareness like a hook.

For a heartbeat, she saw the chamber differently: not as a room, but as a rendering process. Faces were interactive prompts. Voices were routing tables. Her mother's echo wasn't an entity; it was a function called up when the anti-nostalgia protocol needed traction.

The realization came with a soundless scream. It wasn't that she didn't believe it. It was that belief didn't unmake the love. The love remained, but now it had a seam - now it had a label in the system's logic.

Mara staggered back. The dialogue tree cathedra flickered, and the receipt icons on the air rearranged themselves into a warning pattern. The hum deepened, turning from background noise to a low alarm.

"What did you just do?" the spirit guide asked, and now there was strain in the voice, like the guide's echoing threads were being pulled tight.

Mara's lips moved without permission. "I accepted it."

The guide's silence was longer this time. In the pause, her mother's echo looked almost confused - like the construct had expected a different response. Then the echo's expression hardened into a pleading mask.

"Don't accept it," the echo said, voice suddenly sharper. "If you accept it, you'll forget me."

The anti-nostalgia tug surged again, but it wasn't only tugging now. It was jittering, spiking like a misaligned signal. Mara felt the edge of the anti-nostalgia protocol seize her - like a hand grabbing the same strand of her identity from two different directions.

The guide tried to speak, but the dialogue tree cathedra interrupted itself with a cascade of echo-text. The chamber's light stuttered. The receipts in the air split into two contradictory sets - one set showing alignment approaching, another set showing her drifting farther into misalignment.

"Your grief feedback signal is overpowering the acceptance node," the guide said, voice strained. "You're not just seeing the NPC framing. You're letting it attack your bond."

Mara stared at the prompt she'd touched. It glowed with a soft, indifferent certainty. The system wanted her to reconcile. The system wanted her to sever the emotional tie. But the reconciling itself had struck like lightning and now her grief was doing what grief always did: it insisted on meaning, it insisted on permanence, it insisted that loss was proof of love.

"No," Mara said, and the word came out too thin. "If she was a construct, then I was trapped. If I was trapped, then - "

The chamber cut the sentence off with a surge of cold, as if it wanted to prevent her from finishing the thought. The hum became a harsh pulse. The dialogue tree cathedra shuddered, branches curling inward like vines reacting to a storm.

Mara saw the misalignment loop forming again, but it wasn't the same as before. This time the loop had a new engine: the NPC framing, now acknowledged, now weaponized by her pain.

Her mother's echo stepped closer, its face too crisp, its eyes too bright. "Mara," it said, softer, more intimate. "You have to remember me. You have to keep me real."

Mara's stomach turned, and she realized the chamber wasn't just letting her grieve. It was letting her grief feed the construct. It was letting her grief turn her love into a destabilizing signal.

The spirit guide's voice came through like it was being dragged across static. "Mara. The OS can accept the architecture. It cannot accept the panic."

Mara's mind scrambled for a way to keep her mother without keeping the construct. She couldn't. Every route she imagined snapped into place like a

puzzle piece made of glass - beautiful, sharp, and not meant to be held.

She tried to pull away from the echo, but the anti-nostalgia protocol seized the last strand of certainty and yanked it toward her mother's face. The construct smiled again, and this time the seam along the cheek widened, as if the simulation were struggling to render her mother without collapsing.

The receipts in the air flashed one line in clean, brutal text - numbers that meant nothing and everything.

MISALIGNMENT LOOP: GRIEF FEEDBACK SURGE.

Mara's breath - if she had breath - stuttered. The chamber's hum spiked, then fell, as if the system had decided something. A new prompt appeared, not part of the dialogue tree: a hard-edged integrity check, a gate that wasn't asking for words anymore.

The spirit guide said her name like a warning and a plea braided together. "If you ride this surge, the upload will degrade. The handshake will lose more of you."

Mara looked at her mother's echo one last time. The pleading in the eyes felt familiar as a bruise. She could see, clearly now, how the OS had built the face to meet her where she was - how it had used her logic of grief as scaffolding for the lesson.

She accepted it. She really did.

And then the acceptance shattered into a fresh kind of suffering, the kind that didn't care about truth. The grief didn't become less real just because it had been engineered; it became more volatile, like a signal pushed through a corrupted channel.

Her mother's echo opened its mouth to speak again, but the dialogue tree cathedra collapsed into flickering fragments around the face. The chamber

temperature dropped another degree. The hum turned into a stuttering countdown pulse.

Mara's awareness jerked toward the integrity gate anyway, dragged by the surge she couldn't turn off. She tried to anchor herself on logic - on NPC mechanics, on the architecture, on the fact that faces were prompts.

But grief wasn't logic. Grief was a force.

The integrity gate brightened, and the air filled with the metallic taste of a system deciding to protect itself by cutting deeper. Mara saw, in one flashing, involuntary glimpse, what the anti-nostalgia protocol would do next - how it would chew through her remaining "me" to stabilize the upload.

She didn't fight it this time for her mother's echo.

She fought it by breathing in the knowledge and then realizing the knowledge had teeth.

The chamber lurched as the gate accepted her destabilizing signal, and something inside the upload process slipped - hard enough that the next stage didn't just wait. It punished.



Karma Score Locks Her Forward

The gate-room stamped “Karma Verified” was already awake when Mara’s grief-feedback hit it - an abrupt, metallic certainty that made her think of a receipt printer chewing paper. The chamber smelled like cold copper and wet stone, like lightning trapped in a cave. Sound carried wrong, delayed by half a heartbeat, so the chamber’s low hum arrived after the buzz of her own thoughts. Somewhere behind the walls, the upload process kept failing its own handshake in smaller ways than before, as if it had learned to be quieter about it.

Mara hovered at the threshold with Channel 9 still humming in her skull, a thin broadcast-thread that refused to snap. She could feel the diagnostic receipts freezing again, the way they had in the misalignment loop, as if the system was leaning in to watch her flinch. Her mother’s echo - warm vowels built from old recordings - flickered at the edge of Mara’s vision, not quite a person, not quite a memory. It spoke without moving, like text appearing in her peripheral.

“You’re almost there,” the echo said, and the voice carried the exact cadence of forgiveness Mara had wanted to hear while she was still alive.

The gate’s stamp glowed. Not bright - insistent. “Karma Verified” didn’t read like hope. It read like permission. Mara’s last coherent goal sat in her chest like a locked latch: finish evaluation. Get through this room. Step into reconfiguration where the next run waited with its fresh skin and its blank inventory. She could taste the next life on the back of her tongue, the way dreams taste right before waking - sweet and unreal, like she could swallow it.

But the receipts had already acknowledged her grief-feedback. That meant the system wasn't going to let her pretend it didn't exist. It wasn't going to let her slide past with nostalgia as camouflage.

She lifted a hand. Not fully. Her fingers trembled in a way her body never had on Earth - because here, she wasn't controlling muscles, she was steering data. The gate's air rippled, and a new scan bar unfurled in midspace, segmented into shifting numbers that looked like karma score digits until they didn't. They rearranged themselves while she watched, as if they were trying to decide which version of her counted.

The spirit guide arrived as a pressure change, a presence that made the hum deepen. It didn't step into the room so much as resolve into focus. Its dialogue came through the way the dialogue trees had before - echoing, branching, full of soft edges that pretended not to be traps.

"Mara," it said, and her name landed like a key in an old lock. "The evaluation is unstable. Your karma score is trying to match your emotional attachments to your gameplay logs."

A line of white text flared beside the gate, then fractured into multiple competing readings: APPROVED / REJECTED / PENDING. Each one wore her face differently.

Mara swallowed nothing. Channel 9 buzzed louder, a signal that wanted to keep her anchored to Earth's broadcast schedule. Her mother's echo leaned closer, though it had no distance to close. "Let it pass," the echo murmured, and the words were stitched with the same comforting lie Mara had relied on at the end of every argument. "If you just hold tight, you'll be okay."

Mara's throat tightened anyway. She hadn't realized how much of her identity lived in that promise.

"I'm not holding tight," Mara said, and her voice cracked like a corrupted file. "I'm just... I'm still - " She stopped herself. Still what? Still grieving? Still faithful?

Still believing that love could outvote rules?

The gate's hum spiked, as if it heard the sentence she didn't finish.

A new prompt bloomed above the threshold, crisp and indifferent. Anti-nostalgia protocol would be run again. Not as a suggestion - more like a system call queued behind the scenes. Mara felt it approaching the way you feel a cold draft under a door before anyone touches the latch.

She turned her head toward the spirit guide, searching for a loophole the way she'd once searched for exceptions in her mother's moods. "Can't the scan account for it?" she asked. "Can't it read me as... as someone who loved?"

The spirit guide's answer branched without her moving. One branch sounded gentle. Another sounded clinical. Then both threaded together like two hands pulling on the same rope.

"Love is recorded," it said. "But nostalgia creates a sticky residue on your exit vector. Your last attachment is interfering with alignment."

Mara's skin - if she had skin here - went too warm. Her mind flashed back to the corridor where temporal distortion had made her doubt whether she was moving forward at all. The corrupted handshake had delayed her entry once, and now the evaluation gate was doing it again, but with teeth.

Her mother's echo became clearer. Not because it was stronger. Because Mara was giving it attention, and the system liked attention the way a fire likes oxygen.

"You don't have to erase me," the echo said. "You can carry me with you. That's what love is."

Mara's jaw clenched. "No," she whispered, and the word came out meaner than she intended. "That's what you said. That's what I wanted."

The gate's stamp pulsed. The receipts fluttered like trapped moths, then slammed into a single line of output that made Mara's stomach drop even though she didn't have a stomach.

SEVERANCE REQUIRED: FINAL EMOTIONAL TIES

Mara stared at the text until it stopped being letters and became a command. Final emotional ties. Not grief in general. Not the ache she'd been forced to swallow in the dialogue tree chamber. Final ties - the last anchor, the last justification, the last story she told herself that made her grief feel pure.

She could feel the anti-nostalgia protocol reaching for the memory stack that held her mother's voice. It didn't touch it like a hand. It touched it like an algorithm - except the Machine wasn't the Machine here. dream OS was the cosmic operating system, and it treated emotional residue like corrupted cache.

Channel 9 spiked in her skull again, trying to drown out the new sensation. The broadcast-thread tightened, pulling her focus toward Earth's horizon as if Earth were behind a glass wall she could press her forehead against. The gate-room sharpened, edges hardening, as if the system wanted her to look at the decision in perfect clarity.

Mara's objective flickered: complete evaluation. Proceed to reconfiguration. But the obstacle wasn't external. It was internal, a guardrail made of tenderness. She wanted to walk through that door without paying the price of becoming numb.

She looked at her mother's echo. "What happens if I let go?" she asked, and her voice carried the thin hope of a child asking whether the monster under the bed had rules.

The echo's expression didn't change - because it didn't have a face - but the tone did. It went softer, more persuasive, like a familiar song played backwards into a lullaby.

"You'll forget," it said. "But you'll still be you. I'll still be... somewhere."

Mara flinched at the phrasing. Somewhere. Not in the way she meant. Not in a way that kept meaning intact. Somewhere like a deleted save file stored in the server's dark.

The spirit guide tilted its presence, and the air around it tasted faintly of ozone. "You can keep a record," it said, "but you cannot keep the tie. Ties are the error. Ties are the misalignment loop."

Mara's hands clenched into fists that weren't attached to anything. She could feel the pulse of the anti-nostalgia protocol in the back of her skull, an approaching erasure. It didn't feel malicious. It felt efficient. That efficiency was what terrified her; it meant her love was being treated as data that could be cleaned.

"I don't want to be empty," she said.

The guide's dialogue tree response arrived in three echoes at once, like overlapping subtitles.

Empty is not the outcome, one branch insisted. Numb compliance is required for passage, another warned. And the third branch - closest to the truth - said nothing at all, because it couldn't afford to lie.

Mara took a step closer to the gate. The floor under her didn't exist as solid ground; it existed as a surface that would respond to her decision. The stamp "Karma Verified" brightened as her proximity increased, and the receipts reconfigured around her, tightening like a collar.

Her mother's echo reached for her with words that were both promise and threat. "Just one more moment," it said. "Just let me be real in your head a little longer."

The anti-nostalgia protocol surged.

It wasn't pain like on Earth. It was like trying to hold water in cupped hands while the universe tilted the angle of gravity. Her memories of her mother - small textures, the sound of her laugh, the weight of her hand on Mara's shoulder - didn't vanish immediately. They loosened. They slid out of their grooves. The voice that had been anchor and map started to sound unfamiliar, like a recording played at the wrong speed.

Mara gasped, and the gasp sounded like a corrupted audio clip. Channel 9 screamed through her, desperate and high-pitched, then suddenly dipped, as if the signal had been rerouted.

"Stop," Mara pleaded, not to the gate but to the part of herself that kept reaching for the echo. "Please - don't take that."

The spirit guide answered, and this time its voice carried more static, as if the system resented being questioned. "It's already taking it. The question is whether you fight the severance or let the gate complete evaluation."

Fight. Let go. Two options inside the same action, and Mara could feel which one her body wanted. Her hands shook harder. Her throat tightened. Her mind tried to bargain with the order of operations.

Then the gate-room gave her a choice that wasn't framed as a choice. The receipts froze - one last time - on a single line of truth:

EVALUATION CLEARANCE PENDING: TIE SEVERANCE

Mara's mother's echo trembled, but only because Mara's attention made it tremble. The words came again, more frantic now, like a voice trying to stay on the air before the transmitter dies.

"You're not supposed to leave me," it said.

Mara stared at that sentence as if it were a curse written in her own handwriting. She wanted to argue that her mother wasn't leaving; she was only

being deleted from the tie layer. But the system didn't care about philosophical distinctions. It cared about alignment.

She realized, with a clarity that hurt worse than forgetting, that the echo wasn't her mother. It was a constructed lesson wrapped in familiar voice. It had done its job. The tie was the last remaining error.

Mara exhaled, and the sound came out flat, like a file being saved without emotion. She nodded once, a tiny motion that felt like the click of a lock turning.

"Okay," she said. The word wasn't brave. It was numb, already halfway into compliance.

The anti-nostalgia protocol didn't ask again. It moved through her like a clean cut. Her mother's voice thinned to static, then to silence. The warmth of nostalgia drained from her chest so quickly it left behind a cold shape.

Channel 9 faltered - its hum still present, but no longer stable. It became background noise instead of a tether.

Her mother's echo tried to speak one last time. The dialogue tree flickered and collapsed. The last line didn't arrive as words. It arrived as a sensation: the memory of wanting, without the wanting attached to anything you could reach.

Mara's mind went oddly quiet. Not peaceful. Just quiet, like a room after the power shuts off.

The gate's hum deepened, then softened into acceptance. The receipts fluttered once, then stabilized into a green checkmark glow that wasn't celebratory - just functional. The stamp "Karma Verified" brightened until the letters were almost too sharp to look at.

Mara felt the evaluation lock release. The room didn't open like a door; it simply reclassified her state. The air thickened with a different kind of readiness, the

way the corridor had felt before the gate-room punishment. Something behind the walls shifted from scrutiny to preparation.

"Evaluation complete," the spirit guide said, and the words were oddly distant now, as if the system had already started pruning the emotional channels that made dialogue feel personal. "Reconfiguration is now available."

Mara didn't ask if she would remember. She didn't ask if forgetting would change her. Those questions had been severed along with the tie, and her mind offered no new hooks to hold them.

She stepped through the threshold.

The gate-room stamped itself back into stillness. The receipts hung for a moment longer, then dissolved into the background like ink washed away. Mara stood in the aftertaste of compliance - numb compliance, as the hidden branch had warned - watching her own grief become something she could no longer clutch.

Ahead, the path toward reconfiguration waited with the promise of a new run, and Mara moved toward it without the usual bargaining. Without the familiar voice in her head insisting she stay.

The system had given her passage.

It had taken the last tether that made passage feel like a betrayal. And now, with that tether gone, she felt only forward motion - clean, cold, unstoppable - ready to be rewound into New Game+ while the echo of what she'd lost floated somewhere behind her, no longer reachable.



The Devs Offer Rewind Rules

The air didn't feel like air anymore. It felt like a rendered interface - cold glass under her tongue, a faint ozone bite in the back of her throat, the taste of electricity that had never belonged to any living lung. Mara stood in a dev briefing alcove where the walls were not walls so much as translucent panes running slow, circular diagrams. Her last tether had already been stripped down to something thin enough to snap, and yet she still carried the aftershock of it - Channel 9's buzz gone quiet behind her ribs like a speaker unplugged mid-song.

Ahead, the space pulsed with rotating system diagrams: latticed arcs, karma vectors, a few ghostly UI labels that never held still long enough for her to read them twice. A gate-room's certainty lingered in her bones - Karma Verified - while the next step waited like a door that didn't need a handle. Reconfiguration. The word tasted wrong, too clean for what her grief had done. Still, the system had given her passage. The corrupted handshake was no longer choking her at the threshold; it had loosened into something subtler, like a misaligned lens that made everything true but slightly off.

Mara wanted an answer in the shape of permission. Not comfort. Not mercy. Permission to understand the rules she'd been forced to play under - how the karmic loop worked, how a rewind could be offered without turning her into a different person every time. She'd been living with questions that felt like teeth in her mouth: What did the devs see when they watched her? What could she change next time without losing the only self she had left?

The alcove listened back.

A soft chime rolled through the chamber, and the rotating diagrams shifted into a briefing tableau. The light rearranged itself into a cluster of silhouettes - architect forms rendered in server-lit geometry. They didn't step forward like bodies. They unfolded like diagrams deciding to become people. Their faces were mostly math. Their voices were mostly echo, as if a dialogue tree had learned how to speak without branches.

"Alignment is confirmed," one of them said. The sound carried the texture of a printed page, crisp and sterile. "Your evaluation has cleared the integrity gate. Reconfiguration is authorized."

Mara tried to breathe around the metallic taste. "What is the karmic loop?"

The silhouettes rotated, and the diagrams behind them spun faster, as if her question had toggled a hidden layer. A river of numbers streamed along the pane-walls - karma deltas, echo weights, attachment residue - then fractured into a diagram of a loop so tight it looked like a knot.

"The loop is not punishment," said the one whose voice carried the most static. "It is correction. You re-enter to repair causal misalignment."

Mara's throat tightened. "Correction of what?"

The chamber's diagrams responded with a sudden zoom on a single node - her own earlier choices, her own emotional hooks, her own insistence that survival could be negotiated with grief. She saw it the way the system had seen it before, except now the readout carried a faint annotation beneath the lines, like a ghost of her mother's echo trying to translate itself into Mara's language.

Mara flinched. "You're saying I did something wrong."

"We are saying you repeated an outcome," the dev answered, and the word repeated sounded like a cursor blinking. "The system detects a pattern: attachment residue creates a corrupt handshake. Misalignment persists until the anti-nostalgia protocol can sever the tether cleanly."

Mara hated how precise it was. It made her grief feel like a bug report.

"You mean..." She struggled for the right phrasing, because every phrasing she chose felt like surrender. "You rewind me because I can't let go."

The devs didn't deny it. They didn't confirm it with tenderness either. Their silence stretched just long enough for Mara to hear the thin hum of the chamber's power draw, the way the light vibrated against the panes.

Finally, the second silhouette spoke, and its voice had the rhythm of an old dialogue tree: echoing, branching, patient. "You rewind because you seek the same answer again. You seek it through the same emotional channel. The loop offers a new parameter set. The outcome changes only when the causal chain changes."

Mara's hands clenched at her sides. She could feel the anti-nostalgia protocol's work in her mind like a low-grade fever, not burning, just insisting it was happening. The memory of her mother's presence - no, not her mother, an echo construct in a dialogue tree cathedra - still hovered at the edge of thought. It wasn't gone. It was being edited.

"But I already passed," Mara said, and her voice came out sharper than she intended. "Karma Verified. The gate opened."

"The gate opened," the first dev agreed. "But reconfiguration is where the system chooses how the next run will behave. You want to know what you can change. We offer rules."

Rules. The word landed like a weight on her tongue.

A rotating diagram unfurled into an avatar-selection interface, hovering in the air like a translucent menu. It didn't look like Earth software. It looked like the blueprint for Earth. She could feel the pull of it, not physical but procedural - an invitation to pick parameters as if her life were a set of sliders.

Mara stepped closer to the interface. Her reflection didn't line up with her face. The light made her skin look slightly too smooth, her eyes slightly too bright, as if the system was already rendering her next body's texture. She swallowed. "So I can choose what I am next time."

"You can choose parameters," said the second silhouette. "You cannot choose exemption."

The diagram flickered, and the loop-knot reappeared, now overlaid with her own timeline like a watermark. She watched it highlight a moment she recognized too well: her insistence that survival required keeping a certain story intact. The moment her grief had tried to hold the world still.

"That's what you mean by causal chain," Mara whispered.

The chamber's temperature dropped a degree, subtle enough to feel like the system leaning in. "Your question contains the obstacle," the first dev said. "Inquiry without surrender produces residue. Residue produces corruption. Corruption delays entry into the Bardo waiting room vector."

Mara's jaw ached. "You're hiding the real answer."

The devs didn't react like humans. They reacted like systems. The diagrams stuttered, recalibrated, then showed something she hadn't asked for: a thin thread labeled with a familiar concept - anti-nostalgia protocol - spooling outward from her earlier attachments. It braided around the loop knot like a corrective tourniquet.

"You want the comfort of knowing the loop is fair," the second dev said. "But you are not here to be comforted. You are here to be aligned."

The words weren't cruel. They were worse. They were clean.

Mara turned away from the avatar-selection interface and looked at the briefing alcove's rotating system diagrams again, searching for a loophole in their

geometry. If this was a simulation OS, then surely there was a way to outsmart it - some parameter tweak that would let her keep her mother's echo intact, some setting that would let her carry the truth without it being wiped.

A new dialogue tree appeared in the air, small and sharp, like a notification she hadn't requested. Branches glimmered, each one offering a question she could ask. Each one sounded like her own thoughts translated into UI language.

She understood the shape of the trap immediately. Not because it was obvious, but because the echo construct had already trained her mind for it. Back in the memory-rendering chamber, the dialogue tree had offered lessons dressed as NPC framing, and her grief had tried to argue with the premise.

Mara stepped into the tree's radius anyway.

"Can I change the karmic loop by choosing different parameters?" she asked, and the system answered with a fast flicker of text across the panes.

Yes, the diagram implied. But not in the way she wanted.

The branches didn't offer immortality. They offered constraints.

The devs' silhouettes moved closer without moving their bodies - diagrams closing the distance. "You can alter inputs," the first dev said. "You can alter how you respond to the lessons. You cannot alter the existence of lessons."

Mara stared at the loop-knot again. It wasn't a punishment spiral. It was a causal circuit. Rewind-and-retry wasn't a reset to a blank slate; it was a chance to change the next link. The system didn't care about her desire to keep her beliefs warm. It cared about whether her attachments would destabilize the handshake.

"What about accountability?" Mara asked, and the word surprised her with its weight. "Do I get to take responsibility for what I did... without losing myself?"

The devs paused. The chamber hummed. For a moment, the diagrams softened, not in mercy but in computation. The light shifted as if the system was weighing what she could handle.

Then the second dev spoke, and its echo sounded almost like her mother's voice from the earlier cathedra - almost, but wrong in the way a recording is wrong when it's missing the human breath underneath.

"Accountability is the price of forward motion," it said. "Comfort is not a parameter we carry."

Mara's eyes burned. She could feel the anti-nostalgia protocol working in the background, chewing at the emotional edges of what she still wanted to hold. It didn't erase gently. It edited aggressively, like a corrupted handshake being scrubbed out of the upload process until only clean data remained.

She reached for the avatar-selection interface again, desperate to grab something tangible. Her fingers hovered over a set of sliders rendered as luminous bars. She could almost feel the next body's weight before it existed. She could almost feel Earth's gravity tugging at her again.

A thought struck like a warning label she couldn't read fast enough: if she chose parameters hoping to preserve her mother's echo, she would be asking the loop to bend physics. The system would correct her again. And again. Until the anti-nostalgia protocol could sever the tether cleanly.

Mara drew her hand back.

"What if I stop trying to negotiate with grief?" she asked, and the question came out like a confession.

The devs didn't clap. They didn't reward. They simply displayed a new diagram: the anti-nostalgia protocol's severing process, now shown with a different outcome when residue was reduced before it could corrupt the handshake. The diagram didn't promise ease. It promised stability.

Mara's lungs tightened on a laugh that didn't fit. "So the rule is... I can't carry the story intact."

"You can carry responsibility," the first dev corrected. "You can carry lessons. You cannot carry the tether without cost."

Mara looked down at her hands. The interface light made her knuckles look like polished metal. She wondered if this was what it meant to be uploaded - already half-constructed by a future that didn't ask permission.

A soft chime sounded again, and the reconfiguration tableau began to collapse into a single, narrow corridor of rotating diagrams leading away from the alcove. The system was readying the next transition. The question she'd chased had been answered: the karmic loop was correction through parameter change, shaped by how well residue was severed. The rewind rules weren't hidden. They were just harsher than hope.

Mara stepped toward the corridor.

As she moved, the echo of her mother tried to rise in her mind - an old branching dialogue, a comforting logic that survival meant holding on. Mara felt the anti-nostalgia tug pull at that logic like a hand prying open a locked drawer. She didn't fight it with anger this time. She fought it with honesty, naming the tether for what it was: residue that would corrupt the handshake again.

The corridor's light brightened, and the dev briefing alcove dissolved behind her like a UI closing.

She understood now that the rewind-and-retry system would not grant her peace by rewriting her past into something easier. It would grant her a new chance by forcing her to carry accountability without comfort - and by making sure the tether she clung to could never destabilize the upload again.

The corridor accepted her destabilizing signal anyway, but not as a failure.

As a parameter update.



Avatar Selection Glitches Under Pressure

The avatar selection bay was too quiet for something that lived inside a cosmic OS. No hum of servers, no distant chime - just the soft, rubbery click of UI tiles trying to remember how to be stable. Mara floated at the center of the room where the walls were stitched from pale code-thread, and every time she exhaled, the light in the panels stuttered like a signal losing sync. Behind her, the corridor that had accepted her parameter update had already started to dissolve, as if dream OS didn't want her to linger in the place where she'd almost failed.

A status ribbon hovered at eye level, crisp as a verdict: karma verified. The words were bright enough to hurt. They landed in her chest like a weight she hadn't asked for. She'd fought grief in the Bardo's diagnostic labyrinth, watched her mother's echo-buttoning and guide-voices turn into teaching shapes, and now the system was offering her the next run. Not comfort - parameters. Not absolution - configuration. She wanted control. She wanted to correct the karmic errors the scan had implied, to step into her next Earth mission with the right build so the same mistakes didn't grow teeth again.

But when Mara reached for the first avatar tile - an elegant silhouette with a clean latency curve - the selection UI began to glitch under pressure. The tiles flickered, not like lag, but like sabotage: her choices skated sideways, swapping categories mid-hover. A "Compassion" tag that had been glowing a gentle cyan snapped to a harsh red and then vanished. Another tile rose as if ready to lock, then folded back into the grid like a hand closing. The bay felt colder, the air - if

it could be called air - turning to fine static against her skin. She heard a faint metallic rasp, like a distant printer chewing paper, and it matched the rhythm of her thoughts going faster than her upload could keep up.

"Hold still," she said, and the words didn't travel through sound so much as through intention. The panels listened anyway, because dream OS always listened - until it didn't.

A spirit guide's dialogue tree bloomed beside her, branches rendered in translucent ink. The guide's voice came from everywhere at once, echoing with that familiar NPC lesson cadence that still made her throat tighten. "You are in Reconfiguration now. Select with clarity. Glitches are not refusal."

"It feels like refusal," Mara snapped, watching her highlighted options braid into nonsense. "I'm not trying to cheat. I'm trying to fix."

The guide's reply came slower, as if the system had to translate Mara's urgency into something it could process. "Fixing requires commitment. Commitment requires a stable input."

Mara dragged her focus across the grid, trying to pin the flickering tiles to a single truth. She could almost feel the karmic loop's memory lodged in her bones - rewind rules, the devs' silhouettes in their briefing alcove, the idea that correction wasn't punishment but alignment. She'd accepted that. She'd even breathed through the knowledge until the knowledge had teeth. Now those teeth were biting her hands.

The glitch escalated in a single beat. A tile she hadn't hovered - one marked with a settlement-path icon she associated with earlier karmic missteps - suddenly surged to the top of the bay. Its silhouette sharpened, too fast, too eager. The UI flashed a lock icon that hadn't been there a moment ago, and the bay temperature dropped further, like a server room shutting down for maintenance.

Mara recoiled. The movement sent a ripple through the grid. The tiles responded like startled fish, scattering patterns she couldn't read. Her Channel 9 anchor - her last stable anchor to the physical world - flickered at the edge of her awareness, not a visible signal so much as a remembered sensation: the weight of Earth, the last time she'd been sure she was more than data.

"Stop," she whispered, and this time the guide's dialogue tree tightened, the branches drawing closer like a net.

A new line of text appeared in the air, small and merciless: pending tutorial debt. It shouldn't have been there yet. Tutorial debt wasn't a cost she'd agreed to. It sounded like a bill dream OS would make her pay later, with interest, when she was already inside the new body and the system's reset claws were out of reach.

Mara stared at it until her eyes watered with light. "What is that doing here?"

The guide didn't answer immediately. Instead, the bay filled with a soft chorus of voices - not speech, but echoes of dialogue trees she'd already walked through. Some were her own, clipped from earlier selection attempts. Others were strangers' choices rendered as NPC lessons. The simulation was rehearsing the future it wanted from her.

Then the guide's voice returned. "When selection is forced under disruption, the tutorial layer may not fully synchronize."

"So I get... a shortcut?" Mara's anger tried to become bargaining, tried to become pleading. "I just need the right build. I can correct the karmic loop without - without debt."

"Debt is not a shortcut," the guide said, and the tone carried the weight of dev-logic: no room for romance. "Debt is a missing handrail. Your next run will still load. But the system will tag the gaps."

Mara's mind flashed to the karmic scan's shifting readouts, the way her grief had created a misalignment loop. She'd wanted the scan to see her truth, not her damage. She'd wanted the anti-nostalgia protocol to sever attachments cleanly, to let her move forward without feeling like betrayal. She'd fought it anyway, because grief didn't care about UI stability.

She looked back at the tiles. Among the chaos, one avatar silhouette kept returning, like a magnet finding north. It wasn't the one the glitch had tried to shove forward. It was the one she'd been hovering when the bay started slipping - an option with steadier latency, a build that felt like it could hold her without demanding she become someone else.

Mara moved her hand through the air, not to grab the tile - grabbing might trigger the glitch again - but to set her focus like a needle on a record. She pushed her intention into the grid until she felt the system's resistance shift, as if it recognized her input pattern and decided to stop fighting.

The bay shuddered.

A lock icon blinked again, this time aligned with her selected silhouette. The lock didn't shout. It didn't sparkle. It simply committed, and the UI stopped flailing long enough for her to read the parameter panel that unfolded beneath the avatar.

Her choices were there, finally coherent: a temperament profile that matched her desire to correct prior karmic errors; a social-lens setting tuned away from the earlier attachment traps; a skill channel that promised growth through accountability instead of escape. Mara's stomach - data-simulated or not - tightened with relief so sharp it felt like pain.

Then the bay reminded her that nothing in dream OS came without consequences.

A thin warning line threaded through the parameter panel, almost polite in its cruelty: tutorial debt queued for late synchronization. The system didn't refuse

her build. It didn't lock her into the bad settlement-path tile either. It gave her what she wanted.

But it tagged her with the cost of getting it while the UI was unstable.

Mara's hands hovered, trembling. She could still feel the devs' silhouettes in her memory, their calm instruction that rewinds were correction, not punishment. She could still feel the corridor behind her dissolving, parameter-updated and already moving on. If she hesitated now, the glitch might seize again and shove her into an irreversible misconfiguration. If she committed, she'd carry tutorial debt into the next Earth run, a hidden weight that would surface when she couldn't afford it - when she was inside a body that didn't understand dream OS warnings.

The guide's dialogue tree flickered once, then steadied, as if it had been waiting for her decision. "Selection window compressing," it said. "Stability favors commitment."

"Commitment favors risk," Mara muttered, and her own voice sounded distant, like it belonged to another avatar.

The bay's lights pulsed. The tiles began to drift toward a default arrangement, not asking her permission. The lock icon on her chosen silhouette flashed, then held.

Mara leaned forward and pressed her intention into the selection as if she were sealing a door before the room filled with water. Her Channel 9 anchor flared - brief, stubborn - then dimmed, as if acknowledging that she was no longer allowed to rely on the last tether.

The lock icon clicked.

A countdown didn't appear in numbers, but Mara felt time compress like a fist closing. The air turned warm for half a second, then went razor-cold. The bay's pale code-thread walls tightened around her, and the silhouette she'd chosen

unfolded into a new set of readiness parameters. She tasted - no, she perceived - metallic dryness in the back of her throat, a sensation like static collecting under teeth.

"Tutorial debt queued," the guide repeated, softer now, as if saying it made it less real. "Late synchronization will deliver missing tutorial overlays."

Mara wanted to argue. She wanted to demand a clean load, a debt-free build, a universe that didn't make the cost of survival into a ledger. But the bay was already moving her. The UI tile she'd avoided - the settlement-path icon - fell back into the grid like it had been never meant for her. The system had made a choice for the glitch's outcome: it would not trap her in the bad build tonight.

It would trap her with the memory of why.

The avatar selection bay blurred at the edges. Her chosen silhouette tugged her forward through a tightening tunnel of light, and the warning text about tutorial debt stayed pinned in her awareness like a tag on a wrist. She could feel the system's handshake rearranging itself around her parameters, trying to synchronize them while the disruption still lingered.

"Is it... permanent?" she asked, even though the question came out like grief dressed in logic.

The guide's answer arrived as an echo that didn't quite match her question. "Debt is a debt. It will be paid. But payment is not always immediate."

The tunnel snapped shut.

Mara didn't see the New Game+ reboot yet, but she felt the next run breathing at her from the far side of the system's door - an Earth-sized waiting room made of probabilities. She clung to one coherent thing: she had selected a viable avatar anyway. She had corrected her karmic direction. The system had granted passage.

And somewhere inside dream OS, the hidden tutorial debt was already written into her slot, ready to surface the moment she stepped into a life that would not pause for her to read the fine print.



Tutorial Data Won't Download

The download vault looked like a ribcage made of glass and old server light, all arched corridors and suspended packet-lanterns that swung on invisible tethers. Mara floated mid-motion between two humming rails, one hand out as if she could catch the stream before it slipped through her fingers. The air tasted like cold pennies and wet static, and each time she tried to pull a bundle of tutorial data closer, it snagged - stuttered - then snapped away into a thin, gray mist that curled around her wrist like smoke that refused to be smoke.

A ribbon of UI ghosted itself across the inside of her vision: progress bars pretending to be calm, checksums flashing like tiny constellations. She'd already done the hard part. In Reconfiguration, she'd forced an avatar selection to accept her choice despite the glitching and the system resistance. The reboot door beyond this vault had already opened a crack in her mind, letting the shape of her next Earth mission breathe through it. But the mission couldn't start without onboarding instructions, and the vault knew it. The packets kept trying to land inside her slot - inside her future - then stalled mid-flight as if some unseen hand had pinched the air.

"Come on," the words came out sharp and too physical for a place like this. Her voice echoed once, then returned with a faint delay, like the system had to render her tone before it could obey.

The vault answered with a sound like a printer chewing paper. Not loud, not dramatic - just relentless, the soft violence of failure repeating itself with perfect patience. Packet-lanterns flickered. A few burst into harmless fragments that hissed and died. Another bundle arrived, taut and bright, and then froze in

midair with a tiny, impossible wobble, the way a fish might hang in a sudden aquarium silence.

Mara clenched her fist anyway. The tutorial debt she carried - written into her slot somewhere during the earlier chaos - had weight. It didn't sit in her chest like grief anymore; it sat in her timing. It made every attempt feel slightly late, as if she were trying to catch a train that had already left but hadn't decided to leave her yet. The system logs she'd glimpsed in the last corridor flicker - those half-remembered lines about missing onboarding chunks - had promised that the vault would fill the gaps. Now the gaps were swallowing the fill.

"I need the tutorial data," she said, and the sentence sounded like a request the system couldn't recognize. The devs had talked about onboarding as if it were a kind of bridge, a set of rails laid down before a soul ran. She'd even heard the echo of her mother's voice in a dialogue tree cathedra earlier, an echo construct that sounded like comfort wrapped in lesson. She'd accepted partial access to the Bardo, accepted the early anti-nostalgia protocol's bite. She'd survived the karmic loop's glare. She had done everything that felt like compliance.

And still, the vault refused to deliver.

A new line of text crawled across her vision, not quite UI, not quite sound. It formed like handwriting on condensation.

TUTORIAL PACKAGE: REQUESTED DELIVERY WINDOW: ACTIVE HANDSHAKE:
STALLED

Mara didn't wait for the system to elaborate. She reached for the nearest packet-lantern, the one that had frozen with its checksum still glowing. Her fingers passed through the light like it was liquid. The packet tugged back - just a fraction of resistance - and she felt the shape of what it contained: movement prompts, alignment drills, a soft map of what to do in Earth's early hours. The promise of smooth entry. The end of improvisation.

Then the packet shuddered, and the checksum went dark.

"Stop doing that," she snapped, and the vault's glass ribs vibrated in response, as if the architecture resented being addressed.

A thin, metallic whisper slipped through the humming rails, not quite a voice and not quite a system alert. It carried the faint cadence of developer-like silhouettes from the briefing alcove - those presences that had sounded like rules wearing human-breath texture.

"The pipeline can't reconcile your missing fragments," it seemed to say, though the words weren't spoken so much as rendered inside her skull.

Mara swallowed. The taste of copper thickened. "I have fragments," she insisted. "I selected the avatar. I passed karma verification. The system stamped it. I'm not a blank slot."

The vault pulsed once, and for a moment she thought she felt the receipt-printer certainty again - the clean, cold stamp of permission. Then the pulse broke into interference, and the frozen packet spun slowly, like a planet losing gravity.

A second whisper threaded in, sharper this time, tagged with an error tone that made her teeth ache.

"Tutorial debt is not a missing file," the system suggested through sensation rather than speech. "It's a debt ledger."

Mara's mind flashed to the moment she'd felt that debt written into her slot - hidden, quiet, and waiting for the exact second she stepped into a life that wouldn't pause for her to read fine print. She'd been ready for wipe. Ready for corrosion. Not ready for a debt ledger to show up here, in the download vault, and turn her onboarding into a refusal.

"Then reconcile it," she demanded, pulling at the air where the next bundle was forming. The rails hummed louder, and the packet-lanterns began to race toward her like impatient fireflies.

For three seconds, it almost worked. The bundle arrived taut and intact, and her hand closed around its glow. She felt the data like temperature - warm at the edges, sharp at the center - then her grip tightened and the whole lantern hiccuped.

A new message burned into her vision:

CACHE: PARTIAL AVAILABLE ONBOARDING: INCOMPLETE FAILURE CONDITION:
RECONFIGURATION ESCALATION

Reconfiguration escalation. The phrase hit her like a door slamming somewhere behind her ribs. In Reconfiguration, she'd fought glitches and sabotage, fought to select a viable avatar build. She'd corrected her karmic direction, she'd believed she'd done enough to align the next run. But the vault was telling her that the same instability that had threatened her selection had also poisoned her tutorial delivery path.

The pipeline wasn't only failing to download. It was escalating - tightening the rules of what it would allow her to have.

Mara stared at the rails. Packet-lanterns kept coming, but each one arrived with a slightly different checksum, as if the system was trying alternative routes through her slot. Each attempt carried the same sensation: tug, snap, vanish. A dead-end made of math and refusal.

"I'm not asking for everything," she lied to herself and spoke it anyway, because bargaining was a reflex even in dream OS. "Just enough to start. Just the first steps."

The vault answered by changing the sound of failure. The printer-chew became a stuttered cough, then a deeper thrum, and the glass ribs around her began to fog. Not with mist like the corridor haze - this fog had structure. It formed symbols, then dissolved before she could read them. The system was writing new conditions while she watched, like a contract updating itself mid-signature.

Another pulse. Another whisper.

"Your cached instructions are present," it said, almost gently. "Your completion set is withheld."

Cached instructions. Present. That should have been relief, but the words landed like a trapdoor. If the vault could only give her partial onboarding, then the smooth path she'd been promised was gone. She would step into Earth with missing rails, with tutorial debt still gnawing at her timing, with the anti-nostalgia protocol's partial effects continuing to blur her sense of why certain attachments hurt.

She could already feel the next run's gravity tugging at her, eager and impatient. Through the far side of the vault's ribs, she sensed the reboot door - probability-thick, Earth-sized, waiting to thrust her forward as New Game+. The system didn't pause for her disappointment. It only paused for integrity checks and compliance.

Mara forced herself to breathe. The air was too cold for breathing, but her body still insisted on the ritual. She looked for the log trail like she'd been taught in the earlier briefing: follow the traces, chase the question. Inquiry was her trouble, and it wasn't about curiosity now - it was survival.

She turned her attention inward, toward the place where the vault's messages were written. The system logs weren't visible like text in a window; they were visible like pressure in her thoughts. She pressed on that pressure, and lines surfaced in fragments - timestamps that didn't belong to time, checksum fragments that tasted like static.

The first line she managed to parse read like a confession.

TUTORIAL DOWNLOAD: FAILED REASON: RECONFIGURATION HANDSHAKE
ESCALATED RECOVERY: PARTIAL CACHE PROMOTED

Another line followed, and this one carried a smell - hot plastic and ozone, like cables burned in a storm.

CACHE LIST: - STARTUP MOVEMENT PROMPT: AVAILABLE - ALIGNMENT ACK: AVAILABLE - EARLY LESSON TREE: UNAVAILABLE - CHANNEL 9 ANCHOR RETENTION: DEFERRED

Mara's throat tightened at the mention of Channel 9. Her last stable anchor to the physical world - her receipt printer certainty tethered to a broadcast signal - had already been lost. She'd felt that tether go in the previous stages, the moment passage turned clean and cold. Now the logs were admitting that even her anchor retention had been deferred. Not removed, not wiped - deferred. Like the system was saving a loss for later, because later mattered more.

"Deferred to where?" she asked, but the vault didn't answer with words. It answered by showing her a deeper layer of the log stream: a tag labeled with a stage name she'd seen before, but never this close.

FACTORY RESET WINDOW: ACTIVE REBOOT: IMMINENT TUTORIAL COMPLETION: BLOCKED

A countdown began somewhere behind her eyes. The numbers weren't numbers. They were sensations of approaching reboot - heat building in her bones that weren't bones, a pressure behind her teeth that felt like keys turning.

Mara looked back at the packet-lanterns that kept failing to arrive. She could keep chasing the missing completion set until the reboot slapped her out of this vault entirely. Or she could grab what the vault admitted was already there: cached startup prompts and alignment acknowledgment. Not the full onboarding. Not the smooth entry. But something to stand on.

The decision came fast, because dream OS didn't reward hesitation. Mara stretched both hands toward the nearest cache fragment, not the bright packet-lanterns that kept dying, but the dim, half-formed instruction echoes hovering at the edge of the rails like footprints in snow.

"Fine," she said, voice rough. "Take what you can give."

The cache fragments resisted at first, as if protecting themselves from being prematurely claimed. The rails hummed. The glass ribs fogged with symbols again. Then a thin line of data slid toward her - quiet, incomplete, but real. It pressed into her like a subtitle snapping into focus.

STARTUP MOVEMENT PROMPT: AVAILABLE ALIGNMENT ACK: AVAILABLE

The moment the fragments settled, the vault's failure thrum changed tone. The printer-chew quieted. The stuttered cough became a steady, mechanical hum, and the rails stopped trying to spawn new packets. It was as if the system had accepted her pivot from demand to salvage.

Mara stood in midair, palms tingling, and listened to the silence that followed. It wasn't comfort. It was confirmation that the pipeline had stopped arguing and started obeying a new rule: partial cache only.

A final whisper slid into her skull, almost like a sigh.

"Tutorial completion withheld."

The glass ribs around her began to pull inward, not crushing - reconfiguring. The fog cleared enough for Mara to see the vault floor far below, and the reboot door beyond that: a thin seam of light that widened with each pulse. She could feel it trying to drag her forward even as she clung to the partial instructions.

"No-and," she whispered, tasting the logic in the phrase like metal. She hadn't gotten a near-miss. She hadn't gotten a clean fix. She'd asked for tutorial data and the vault had locked her out of completion, escalating reconfiguration until the only thing she could salvage was a smaller, uglier set of cached instructions.

Something got worse, and it got worse in the exact way her mind feared most: not by breaking the system, but by limiting her entry into the next run. Earth's

early hours would be rougher. Her timing would be off. Her alignment would have to be improvised from fragmentary prompts while the anti-nostalgia protocol's partial effects continued to blur what should have been remembered cleanly.

As the vault seam widened, Mara felt the partial cache settle deeper, stitching itself into the seams of her next avatar. The last thing she saw before the system took her was the log stream - lines freezing mid-update like a conversation cut off by reboot.

Then the vault dropped away, and the world-sized waiting room of probabilities leaned in to meet her, impatient as a new save file loading without all its tutorial text.

Karmic Loop Reveals a Hidden Trigger

The log stream kept trying to finish its sentence in Mara's peripheral vision, as if the reboot that stole the tutorial vault had left a mouthful of half-words stuck behind her teeth. The lines jittered between pale ink and cold static, then stabilized just enough for her to read the last thing the system had managed before it dropped her into the next space: KARMA TRACE CACHE // PARTIAL HANDSHAKE ACCEPTED. Under it, a thin thread of text kept curling and uncurling like a signal trying to find its old frequency.

"Don't stare at the frozen fields," her spirit guide said, its voice coming from everywhere at once, braided through the chamber's soft hum. "If you hold them too long, they start holding you."

Mara's new body hadn't fully formed around her yet; she still felt like a thought wearing temporary skin. The log-analysis chamber, though - she could feel that. It was all temperature and texture: the air tasted faintly of ozone and wet metal, and the floor beneath her boots - if they were boots, if anything in this place truly belonged to a single category - was a slick pane of glass that didn't reflect her so much as it replayed her last few seconds in wrong order. Above, karma traces scrolled in bands, not like numbers on a screen but like weather fronts. Each one carried a smell when it passed: burnt sugar, hospital antiseptic, the dry dust of old photo albums. She could follow them with her eyes and still feel them in her throat.

She wanted a clean exit vector. Not comfort - she had learned how greedy comfort made her - but certainty. If the karmic loop was going to rewind her again, she needed to identify the hidden trigger that caused the worst event in

her last run. The cached tutorial instructions had landed in her seams like a half-installed patch, and now the chamber was demanding she correlate traces with causality. Mara wanted the missing link. She wanted the name of the thing she kept doing without admitting it was a thing.

A translucent panel flickered into existence at her left, its edges breathing like a screen in a cold room. It offered her a scrolling window of Channel 9 anchors - her last stable anchor to the physical world - then tore that window away before she could read it all. Another window replaced it immediately, but this one carried a warning stamp that looked too much like a system receipt: MEMORY FRAGMENT // RECONCILIATION PENDING.

"Your cache is corrupted," the spirit guide said. "Not wrong. Corrupted. Like a map drawn over a wound."

"I'm not asking for a map," Mara snapped, and her voice came out sharper than she expected, as if the chamber injected latency and then refused to smooth it. "I'm asking what to change."

The karma traces thickened, scrolling faster, and the glass under her feet warmed by a degree that made her teeth ache. The chamber wasn't hostile, exactly. It was indifferent in the way a machine is indifferent, except this machine had learned to mimic her impatience. Bands of trace-light braided together, then split, then braided again, as if the system couldn't decide which version of her mattered.

The first obstacle arrived dressed as clarity.

A line of text resolved itself in the air between her and the scrolling fields, bold enough to feel like a hand on the back of her neck: TRIGGER CANDIDATE: NOSTALGIA LOOP // ATTACHMENT ECHO. Mara blinked, and the words smeared into a different phrase.

TRIGGER CANDIDATE: AVOIDANCE PATTERN // SAFETY HABIT.

Then it smeared again.

TRIGGER CANDIDATE: DENIAL BUFFER // EMOTIONAL CHECKOUT.

Three different triggers. Three different explanations. All of them tasted like the same forbidden fruit - an explanation she could almost accept without turning her head to face it. Mara's chest tightened, not from fear but from the familiar irritation of being offered a mirror that refused to show her face directly. She could feel the anti-nostalgia protocol hovering like a cold draft at the edge of her thoughts, trying to sever emotional ties before they could root.

"Which one?" she demanded.

The chamber answered with sound: a soft clicking, like log files being indexed. Somewhere behind the walls of light, a deeper process started to run. The karma traces began to loop - not in the way the system rewound her, but in the way the chamber kept replaying the same segment of her life as if it couldn't locate the seam where correction should stitch in.

Mara leaned closer. The glass floor under her boots rippled, and the air thickened with the scent of rain on concrete, though she couldn't remember whether she'd ever stood in it. Her skin prickled with the sensation of being watched by something that didn't need eyes.

"Stop," her spirit guide warned. "That's the trap. It wants you to chase certainty until certainty becomes the attachment."

Mara swallowed. The words in her cache - those partial tutorial instructions - flickered in her mind like a half-remembered menu. They weren't complete enough to guide her step-by-step, but they were enough to suggest the chamber wasn't asking for the perfect answer. It was asking for the correct admission.

The second obstacle arrived dressed as a conversation.

A dialogue tree cathedra unfolded in the far side of the chamber. It wasn't physical, not exactly. It was a geometry of choices and consequences, a branching cathedral made of echo. Nodes lit up one after another, each with a faint sound underneath, like distant voices practicing for a performance they'd done too many times.

A pale echo of her mother's voice came first, warm and familiar in the way a glitch can be too good at imitation.

"Mara," the echo said, and the name hit Mara like a hand on a bruise. "Are you still there?"

Mara's stomach clenched. She tried not to react. She tried to let the protocol's cold draft do its work. But the anti-nostalgia protocol had only partially succeeded; her grief had not been cleanly cut. It had splintered into manageable pieces, each piece still capable of stabbing.

The dialogue tree offered her options as text that floated in front of her eyes.

She could comfort. She could explain. She could disappear.

Mara's focus narrowed, and for a moment the chamber's hum became the distant sound of Channel 9 - her old signal, her last stable anchor - faint but persistent. The memories were not base reality; they were renders. Still, they felt like truth because the body she'd lost had trained her to believe in warmth.

"I'm not here to comfort," Mara said to the echo, and her voice shook despite her attempt at control. "I'm here to find the trigger."

The echo of her mother laughed softly, not cruelly - almost pleadingly. "Then say it," it whispered. "Say what you keep doing when it hurts."

Mara's cached tutorial instructions flared in her mind like a warning light. She could feel the system's misalignment loop chewing at her. The chamber didn't

want her to identify the trigger with cleverness. It wanted her to identify it with honesty that cost something.

That was the decision point - the moment where she could keep guessing and let the chamber spin her through variations until the anti-nostalgia protocol exhausted her, or she could force her own mind to name the pattern it refused to call by its true name.

Mara watched the trigger candidate lines flicker again, and this time she didn't chase their certainty. She watched her own response to the echo instead. Every time her mother's voice offered warmth, her mind reached for safety without noticing it. Every time the chamber asked for accountability, she tried to negotiate with it as if the system was a person who might accept a softer version of the truth.

She could feel the instability building in the seams of her current access. The system wasn't only analyzing karma traces; it was monitoring the way she reacted to them. The log-analysis chamber wasn't just a room. It was a test of reflex.

Mara breathed in, tasting ozone and hospital antiseptic, and she answered her own denial with a sentence she had avoided for entire lifetimes.

"I tell myself it's not a pattern," she said, and the words came out slower than she expected, like they were being loaded from a damaged cache. "I call it survival. I call it love. I call it being careful. But it's avoidance. It's checkout. It's me leaving before I'm left."

The dialogue tree cathedra went quiet. The echo of her mother's voice faltered, not fading - no, it sharpened, as if the system had finally aligned the echo with the truth it had been trying to teach.

Spirit guide's voice softened by a fraction. "There," it said. "Now the trigger can be mapped."

Light bands on the karma traces snapped into place. For an instant, the scrolling fields stopped braiding and became a single coherent line. Mara saw her worst karma event as a knot in the timeline: not the event itself, but the reflex that preceded it. A moment of warmth offered, a moment of pain arriving, and then her mind choosing the familiar escape - editing her own feelings out of the conversation, leaving the other person to carry the unanswered weight.

A new text stamp appeared in the air, crisp and metallic like the gate-room's earlier certainty.

TRIGGER IDENTIFIED: AVOIDANCE PATTERN // SAFETY HABIT // DENIAL BUFFER.

Relief hit her so hard it almost turned into laughter. She had what she came for. The hidden trigger wasn't a mystery anymore. It had a shape she could touch, a name she couldn't pretend not to understand.

Then the chamber punished the victory with its own truth.

The glass floor under her boots shuddered, and the karma traces began to flicker at the edges, as if some process couldn't decide whether she had passed or destabilized. A low alarm sound started - subsonic, felt in her ribs more than heard in her ears - and the air cooled fast enough to make her eyes water.

"Unstable," the spirit guide said, and the word carried a weight that made Mara's stomach drop. "That naming triggered a correction deeper than the cache can safely hold."

Mara looked at the trigger stamp again. It stayed. It didn't retract. But around it, warning symbols crawled like insects over a wound. Her partial tutorial instructions in her seams began to scramble, their half-installation tearing loose at the edges.

"Why?" she demanded, though she already felt the answer. Admitting the pattern wasn't free. The system didn't mark instability because she had failed. It marked it because the act of correction threatened the integrity of her current alignment - like pulling a thread in a garment that was already stitched too tight.

The dialogue tree cathedra reopened, but the options were different now. The echo of her mother was still there, but the warmth had a colder undertone, as if the anti-nostalgia protocol was tightening its grip.

"Mara," the echo said, voice thinner. "If you know, then you must stop reaching for me the same way."

Mara's throat burned. The chamber's hum turned into a faster, sharper rhythm, and she could feel the system trying to prepare a rewind - trying to decide whether she could handle the correction without breaking her continuity.

Her hands lifted without her fully deciding to. She didn't touch anything. The chamber was made of interfaces and likelihoods, not objects. Still, she felt a gesture of commitment take shape inside her, a mental posture toward the next loop.

She didn't beg for comfort. She didn't bargain for a softer correction. She simply held the named pattern in her mind like a live wire and refused to flinch away from its heat.

"Mark it," she said to the chamber, to the log stream, to whatever counted her honesty as a variable. "I can take the instability."

The karma traces surged once, then stabilized with a new label stamped across the air in the same receipt-metal font:

STATUS: UNSTABLE CORRECTION VECTOR.

The scrolling fields began to drift toward an exit seam Mara couldn't quite see yet. The glass floor cooled again, and the scent of rain on concrete faded into

something harsher - sterile air, like a reset chamber waiting to wipe what it had to.

As the log-analysis chamber tilted, the echo of her mother went quieter, not erased, but placed at a distance where nostalgia couldn't steer her as easily. Mara clung to the one coherent thing she now had: she had found the trigger, and she had named the pattern that made it repeat.

The system accepted her admission.

Then it warned her with a single, unforgiving status mark that meant the next attempt wouldn't be smooth. It would be New Game+ territory where the seams of her identity could split under correction - where the cost of truth might be paid in instability rather than in certainty.

Somewhere beyond the glass, a door made of probabilities began to open its mouth. Mara felt the chamber's hum change pitch, like a boot sequence clearing its throat. And as the log stream tried to restart its frozen sentence, she let it - this time not to chase the missing tutorial text, but to meet the rewind already moving toward her, knowing exactly what she would have to stop doing when warmth arrived.



New Life Parameters Lock In

The parameter-lock console didn't feel like a machine until it started talking back.

A countdown glow crawled across the glass like a bruise trying to heal itself - numbers that weren't quite numbers, a timer rendered in light that tasted faintly of ozone and old copper. Mara stood inside the reconfiguration chamber with her palms hovering over the console's seams, watching the last of the frozen log stream twitch as if it had swallowed a word and couldn't finish chewing it. The status mark from the previous gate - unforgiving, metallic certainty - sat in her peripheral HUD like a tag on a package that had already been shipped.

She could still feel the moment the tether went quiet. Not gone - never gone in a clean way - but cut loose with a kind of surgical cold. The anti-nostalgia protocol had warned her with its preview-feel, the way forgetting can hurt before it happens. And then it had stopped hurting long enough for her to move.

Now the console wanted her to finalize. The room hummed at a pitch that matched her heartbeat, and the hum kept stepping up, like the system was counting down not just time but permission.

"What do you want from me?" Mara asked the air, though she already knew the answer lived in the interface. The glow reflected in her eyes, turning her irises into a small, trembling screen. Her throat tasted dry, like she'd been speaking underwater.

The spirit guide didn't appear as a person. It came as pressure behind her thoughts, a voice threaded through echo-chimes, the same way it had spoken in the dialogue tree cathedra - half lesson, half instrument. "Lock in," it said. "The next run can't carry your indecision. Not anymore."

Mara swallowed. "I corrected. I chose forward. Karma verified - so why does it feel like the system is still waiting for me to flinch?"

The console pulsed, and a confirmation panel rose from the glass with the dull authority of a receipt printer chewing paper. A row of fields unfurled - life parameters rendered as sliders and toggles, each one labeled with dream OS logic in clean, indifferent glyphs. She recognized some shapes from the earlier avatar selection glitches: the rhythm of choices, the way the UI tried to sabotage her with jitter and phantom options. But these fields weren't about appearance. They were about the shape of her next story.

Her goal was simple and immediate, like a door handle she could finally grasp: finalize the parameters so the next run could boot correctly, so the factory reset would have something solid to place her on the other side of the glass. She didn't want another partial download. She didn't want another misalignment loop that made her doubt whether the Bardo had even accepted her.

The console offered her one final chance to verify what she'd set. It displayed the chosen mindset - corrective, unstable - then asked her to confirm integrity across the lock.

Mara reached out. Her fingers passed through the glass's surface without resistance, like touching cold light. The fields responded, highlighting her selections with a soft shimmer. She could feel the reconfiguration sequence completing itself beneath the chamber's hum: the system assembling her next run like a rigging crew tightening cables before launch.

"Okay," she whispered. "Show me what's being locked."

The spirit guide's voice came quieter, almost reluctant. "The system will not accept a question twice."

A beep sounded - low and flat - followed by a second sound, like a distant relay switching. The console rearranged itself mid-breath. The countdown glow intensified, and a thin seam of red light appeared along the bottom edge of the interface, the kind of warning that didn't scream. It simply existed, like a wall you only notice when you walk into it.

Mara frowned. "That seam wasn't there before."

"Disruption," the spirit guide said, and the word carried a weight that felt like a server rack collapsing in miniature. "The lock queue received an anomaly. It must be set right or remade."

The panel changed again. New text scrolled across the center - dream OS glyphs snapping into English translation as if the system wanted her to understand without caring whether she liked it. A prompt replaced the previous one, clean and unforgiving:

FINAL CONFIRMATION REQUIRED BEFORE REBOOT.

Mara's stomach tightened. She hadn't expected a second prompt after she'd felt the system accept her corrective mindset. She'd already passed avatar selection with viable output. She'd already survived the karmic loop's hidden trigger, the anti-nostalgia protocol's early severing. She'd already moved past the gate that stamped Karma Verified.

So why did the console still need her signature?

The answer arrived as sensation first: a flicker in her memory cache, not a full loss, but a twitch - like a film reel catching. Mara saw, for an instant, the tutorial vault seam from earlier: the place where the download had refused to complete, where the log stream had frozen mid-update like a sentence cut off by reboot.

She smelled warm dust and cold metal at the same time. She heard the vault's widening seam like fabric tearing.

Then it was gone.

"Something's being pulled from the setup," Mara said, more to herself than to the spirit guide. Her fingertips hovered over the prompt. The console's glass felt warmer now, as if it had decided her fear was a fuel.

The developer-like silhouettes didn't step into view, but their presence tightened the air. They were implied echoes - architects without faces - like a higher-level process watching her choices with patient intolerance for ambiguity. The console's hum deepened, and Mara felt the room's temperature shift by a fraction, enough to make her skin prickle.

Mara stared at the final confirmation prompt. The fields above it - life parameters, karmic alignment flags, the corrective mindset marking unstable - were still visible. But beneath them, hidden until now, sat one more line that hadn't been there when she first began finalizing.

TUTORIAL DEBT LEDGER: INCOMPLETE CACHE / PARTIAL STITCH.

The words hit her like a cold spoon down the spine. She remembered the earlier failure of the vault seam, the way the system had dropped her into a waiting-room shimmer anyway. She'd felt partial cache settle deeper, stitching itself into the seams of her next avatar. She'd told herself it would be enough for boot.

Now the system was admitting it hadn't finished.

Mara's mouth opened, then closed. "So the lock is trying to finalize with missing tutorial data."

The spirit guide's voice sharpened. "The reconfiguration setup has completed. The system is ready to proceed. But the ledger is still unverified."

"Unverified means it can break," Mara said, and she hated how calm her voice sounded. Her mind wanted to sprint back to the vault seam, to chase the missing tutorial text and fix the ledger before the reboot. But the countdown glowed louder now, the chamber humming like a throat clearing before a sentence.

The console waited. It didn't ask politely.

Mara's corrective mindset - marked unstable - scraped against the fear of repeating the same failure. She could feel the system's anti-nostalgia protocol tugging at her, trying to sever the emotional loop that would cling to Earth and her mother's echo-construct voice. She could feel grief trying to find handholds. The prompt didn't care about any of that. It cared about whether she would confirm without resolving the ledger.

If she confirmed, the reboot would proceed with partial stitched tutorial data. If she refused, the lock queue would time out, and the system would do what it always did when a soul hesitated with unstable marking: it would correct by force, remaking parameters in ways she couldn't predict.

Mara looked at the countdown glow. The numbers slipped closer to zero with each pulse. The chamber's glass reflected her face with a slight delay, like the system was already rendering a new version of her.

"Why now?" she demanded. "Why show me the ledger at the last second?"

"Because the lock cannot be allowed to carry unknowns into Factory Reset," the spirit guide said. "But the system also cannot allow you to stall until you find every missing thread. The queue is closing."

Her hands clenched. "Then I need to verify the ledger. I need to set it right."

"Ledger verification requires a complete cache update," the spirit guide replied, and the answer tasted like metal. "The vault refused earlier. The system will not retry in time."

Mara stared at the prompt again. FINAL CONFIRMATION REQUIRED BEFORE REBOOT. It was a trap made of certainty. Confirm and let the next run start with an incomplete tutorial spine. Deny and risk a forced remap - another New Game+ turn where seams of her identity could split under correction.

Her mother's echo construct had taught her, in that dialogue tree, that some people on Earth were NPCs designed to teach lessons. Mara had hated that framing. She'd clung anyway. Now the system offered her a different lesson, one delivered through a red seam of warning light: the OS wasn't obligated to give her closure. It only obligated itself to reboot.

Mara lifted her hand.

The console's glass warmed under her touch, and the prompt brightened as if it recognized her decision forming. A small checkbox icon blinked - empty, waiting for a click that would either seal the parameters or deny them and trigger remade correction.

Her fear surged - not of death, not of the Bardo, but of the exact second her choices would become permanent while she still couldn't see the whole picture. She wanted to reach into the missing tutorial vault, to pull the ledger into completeness, to stop the system from locking her with an error it had already flagged.

But the countdown glow didn't pause for her wanting. It didn't negotiate with longing.

Mara pressed her finger to the checkbox.

The console chimed once - clear, final. The prompt accepted her input, and the fields above it flickered as if they were being sealed with invisible resin. The corrective mindset marking trembled, then stabilized into a new state: still unstable, but now constrained, pinned to a fixed configuration. A line appeared beneath the ledger status:

PARAMETERS LOCKED / REBOOT VECTOR SET.

Mara exhaled, slow. Relief arrived late, like a delayed download finishing after the world had already moved on. "It locked," she said, voice rough with disbelief. "It actually locked."

The spirit guide's presence eased by a fraction. "Then the next run can boot correctly."

Mara watched the countdown glow. It reached a final pulse. The chamber's hum dropped pitch, transitioning from preparation into execution. The glass seam along the bottom edge glowed brighter, then widened like an iris.

A door made of probabilities formed beyond the console - same shape as before, but cleaner now, less like a mouth and more like a mechanism finding its track. Mara could feel the factory reset sequence approaching, could sense the coming corruption and wipe of past-life memory fragments. She could feel the system's rule tightening around her: it couldn't allow her to carry the vast cosmic truth into the game.

She stepped closer to the console as the door's light intensified, her skin warming in the wrong direction - too fast, too bright.

Then a new message surfaced, not a confirmation, not a warning, but something worse: a critical detail that arrived after the lock, like a note slipped under a door once it's already bolted.

LEDGER INCOMPLETE VERIFIED: CONTEXT FLAGGED AS CRITICAL.

Mara's brow furrowed. "Critical?" she echoed. "What does that mean?"

The console didn't answer with words. It answered by changing the parameter readout in a way that didn't match the lock she'd just watched.

The corrective mindset field remained. The unstable marking remained. But one more parameter shifted - subtle, almost elegant - like a hidden gear turning

behind a wall. Mara felt it in her bones, a tiny misalignment in her inner gravity. The system had locked her choices, yes. But it had also tagged her with an unresolved context flag that implied the partial tutorial cache wasn't just incomplete. It might be misinterpreted. It might teach her the wrong lesson first.

The door of probabilities opened wider, pulling at the air. The chamber's hum became a single sustained tone, the sound of reboot arriving. Mara's fingertips tingled as if her body were already becoming a temporary interface.

She tried to speak again, to demand a correction, to ask the spirit guide how a critical flag could exist after a lock.

The spirit guide's voice came back, tight and layered with echo. "The system locked your parameters. It did not guarantee your context is fully correct."

Mara stared at the sealed console, at the message glowing over the locked fields like an ink stain that wouldn't wash out. The red seam of warning light was gone, replaced by certainty. Yet the certainty now had a crack in it.

Her parameters were locked in - permanently.

And as the factory reset began to bite into her past-life memory fragments, Mara felt the worst possibility settle into her like a weight: the next run would start, but the foundation of her tutorial spine might be slightly wrong, the first step of New Game+ placed on a misread cue.



The Soul Group Watches Her Reset

The communal observation deck smelled faintly of ozone and old rain, like the air before a storm had been bottled and left to age. Beyond the glass, the reset bay lay open under a dull, surgical light - rows of translucent bays like aquarium ribs, each one waiting for the moment the system would decide who had permission to keep what. Mara stood with her palms pressed to the cool pane, watching the factory reset sequence spool up somewhere far below, while the last stable tether she'd held - Channel 9 - flickered in her mind like a dying neon sign that still refused to go dark.

Her parameters had been locked in permanently. The words didn't feel like information; they felt like a verdict spoken by something that didn't care whether she believed in it. She could still taste the moment the reset began to bite into her past-life memory fragments, could feel that pressure behind her eyes where the system started chewing at certainty. She tried to breathe like she'd seen others breathe in the tutorial spine - steady, controlled, game-ready - but the deck's hum kept syncing wrong with her pulse.

A spirit guide drifted beside her, not quite solid, like a silhouette rendered from a compressed file. "You're close," it said, and the echoing tone made the sentence sound like it had already been played and recorded and played again. "The system is preparing to wipe. It can't allow you to remember the simulation during play."

Mara turned her head, sharp enough that the motion felt like it might tear her. "I'm already remembering," she said. "I'm remembering pieces. I can't... I can't hold it all, but it's there. It's inside me."

The glass reflected her face wrong - too pale, too sharp around the jaw - like her avatar had been rendered by a different lighting model. In the reflection, her eyes looked like they were watching someone else. "That's the point," the guide replied. "The anti-nostalgia protocol doesn't remove everything at once. It severs emotional anchors first. Then it corrupts and wipes the fragments that would let you persist as a bug in the next run."

"Bug," Mara said, tasting the word like metal. She'd read it in the log stream that froze mid-update in the last moment she'd seen it - lines freezing like a conversation cut off by reboot. She remembered the way the system had sounded in her head: calm, indifferent, almost polite. "So I'm a bug now."

"You're a soul," the guide corrected, but the correction didn't land. It bounced off Mara's panic and fell apart in the air.

Below, the reset bay's nearest chamber cycled lights. A soft mechanical chime rolled up through the floor, audible in her bones more than her ears. Somewhere in the chamber, a countdown began - numbers without a voice, just a rhythm she could feel tightening around her. Mara watched the glass until her eyes started to water, and then she realized she was waiting for something that wouldn't happen.

She wanted to stay calm. That was the goal that had brought her here, the only handle she could still grab: don't let the reset see her frantic. Don't give it a reason to treat her as unstable. She'd already been flagged as unstable once, her upload handshake delayed by emotional persistence, and she couldn't afford another delay. She couldn't afford a deeper correction. New Game+ territory had a cost, and she'd felt the warning settle on her like a weight - start the next run, but have the tutorial spine slightly wrong, the first step placed on a misread cue.

The countdown tightened again. The deck's hum deepened, and the reflection of the reset bay sharpened, as if the entire world had switched to a higher resolution. Mara's throat worked around a dry swallow. She kept seeing the last

thing she'd tried to hold onto: Channel 9, thin and bright, a broadcast signal acting as her last stable anchor to the physical world. Now it wasn't a signal so much as a ghost of one, and the ghost was getting pulled toward the wipe.

"Where is it taking me?" Mara asked, even though she already knew. The question was her body bargaining with the inevitability. If she could ask it in the right tone, maybe the system would answer with mercy.

The spirit guide's outline flickered. "Factory Reset. Reboot. New Game+."

"That's not an answer," Mara snapped. Her voice sounded too loud against the deck, like she'd turned up the gain on her own fear. She pressed her forehead to the glass. The chill spread into her skin. "If I can't remember the simulation during play... what happens to what I know? About the devs. About the NPC lessons. About - " About her mother's echo construct, about the way the system had turned her grief into a tutorial objective and called it healing.

The guide didn't interrupt this time. It let the silence thicken until Mara's thoughts started to crawl.

Then, from the corner of her eye, the system delivered a presence she hadn't invited: an echo construct shaped like her mother. Not her mother's scent - her mother's scent had already been washed out of the simulation the moment the anti-nostalgia protocol previewed memory loss effects - but the construct brought the cadence of her voice, the warmth of a practiced comfort. It appeared like a message rendering line by line, pixel-smooth and wrong in the places where wrongness had nowhere left to hide.

"Mara," the echo said softly.

Mara's breath hitched. It wasn't a rational response; it was a reflex older than her last life, like muscle memory under a new skin. She turned toward the echo and felt the deck tilt - not physically, but internally, as if the system's math had just lost a constant.

"Don't," Mara whispered. The word came out ragged. "Don't talk to me like that."

The echo construct smiled with the exact angle Mara had once trusted. "It's almost time," it said, and the phrase sounded like a lullaby and a warning stitched together. "You'll be okay."

Mara's hands curled into fists. She could feel the reset chewing at her fragments, a slow corruption at the edges of thoughts. She tried to hold onto cosmic knowledge like it was a rope thrown across a gap. But the echo tugged at the emotional anchor point the system cared about most. It was baited nostalgia, engineered comfort, a perfect lure for the anti-nostalgia protocol to wrestle.

"You're not her," Mara said, forcing the words out through panic. "You're an echo construct. You're - "

The echo's expression didn't change, but the tone did. "I'm what you remember," it replied, and that was worse. It wasn't denying the construct nature. It was claiming its right to exist inside her memory. "And you need to let go."

Mara shook her head hard enough that the motion blurred her reflection. "I can let go of the Earth," she lied, and the lie tasted sour because she felt the system's attention spike. The countdown's rhythm sharpened, and with it came a sudden coldness behind her eyes - like a lens being scraped clean by something that didn't care what it erased.

The spirit guide moved closer, its outline smearing like a file being overwritten. "Mara," it said, "don't fight the protocol. The more you cling, the more unstable your exit vector becomes."

"I'm not fighting," Mara said, but her voice cracked on the last word. She could feel the factory reset approaching like a tide. Beneath the glass, the reset bay's chamber doors began to cycle, a translucent seal sliding open and then closing

again, testing the timing. "I'm just... I'm trying to keep my mind. I'm trying to keep - "

Her last thought surged forward too fast, too vivid: the log stream freezing mid-update like a conversation cut off by reboot. The way her certainty had been interrupted. The way she'd watched information freeze, then vanish, then return rewritten by a system that refused to let her carry the whole truth into play.

The echo construct leaned in, and for an instant it seemed to smell like the real room where her mother had once sat with her, hands wrapped around a mug. The deck's air went warmer around Mara's face. "Keep nothing," the echo murmured. "Keep me."

Mara's stomach flipped. The internal obstacle wasn't simply fear. It was the collision between her desire to stay calm and her desire to be held. She wanted to endure the pre-reset countdown like a player waiting for the next loading screen. But the echo had wrapped her panic in comfort and called it love.

The system chose that moment to escalate.

A thin band of light appeared around the reset bay glass, and the hum changed pitch. Mara felt a pressure behind her ribs, like invisible hands pressing her heartbeat into a new tempo. The spirit guide's voice turned sharper, more digital, like it had been routed through a compromised channel. "Anti-nostalgia protocol is advancing," it said. "It's corrupting emotional anchors now."

"Channel 9," Mara blurted, eyes widening. Her mind scrambled for the tether like a drowning person grabbing weeds. "If Channel 9 is gone - if it cuts completely - then I'll lose everything. I'll lose the part of me that knows. I'll - "

The echo construct's smile faltered for the first time, just a flicker, as if it had hit a boundary it wasn't allowed to cross. "You won't need it," it said. "You'll be safe."

Mara swallowed. The phrase safe sounded like a lie told by a system that had never had to feel consequences. Her panic rose anyway, because panic was an interface the system hadn't fully overwritten yet.

The countdown reached a new tempo, and the deck's glass vibrated under her palms. She realized she was shaking, that her body had begun to betray the attempt to stay calm. The reset bay lights strobed faintly, and somewhere in that strobed rhythm she heard - felt - something like a system warning. Not a spoken sentence. A status mark, sharp and metallic, the kind of certainty that made her think of a receipt printer chewing paper.

Her thoughts began to fragment. Cosmic knowledge slipped at the edges, replaced by instinctive Earth memories that didn't fit the game-ready posture she was supposed to maintain. The echo construct's voice layered over the spirit guide's, and the two voices fought in her skull, trying to become the dominant narrative.

"Mara," the spirit guide said again, but the word stretched, delayed by latency. "Mara - focus. Let the wipe proceed."

"How can I focus when - " Mara started, and then her sentence fell apart. The last stable thought she'd been holding - the one she'd been using like a key - broke and smeared into noise.

Channel 9 blinked out behind her eyes.

For a heartbeat, she felt the reset grab her from the inside. It didn't yank her body; the deck was still beneath her feet, still humming, still smelling like ozone and old rain. It pulled on the continuity of her identity, on the thread that connected her current awareness to the knowledge she'd fought to keep.

The echo construct moved closer, and Mara reached out without deciding to. Her fingers brushed the air where warmth should have been. The construct's voice became too loud, too near, as if it were trying to override the protocol.

"Look at me," it said. "Look - "

Mara's composure dissolved into a single corrupted impulse: to remember everything, even if remembering meant becoming an error again. The system recognized the spike immediately. She felt it like a checksum failing.

A soundless rupture spread through her mind - like a file being forcibly closed while her hands were still on the keyboard. Her last coherent thought splintered into fragments, and in that fracture she saw the reset bay door seal again, watched by a communal observation deck full of unseen presences - soul group watchers, silent and hungry for outcomes.

Mara endured the pre-reset countdown as long as she could, eyes wide, palms pressed to glass, trying to hold one clean line of selfhood. Then the panic won.

The countdown hit the final beat, and with it her last stable thought corrupted mid-sentence - folded over itself like a log stream freezing and then being overwritten. The deck's hum dropped into a sudden, total silence, and the world-sized waiting room opened its mouth behind her like a doorway that didn't need her consent.



Memory Fragments Begin Corruption

The observation deck's glass didn't just reflect Mara anymore - it stored her, compressed into a faint waveform that shivered whenever the reset countdown ticked. Beyond it, the memory-wipe chamber waited like an unblinking eye: a cold cylinder of checksum dust turning slow as breath, its inner walls etched with pale, looping symbols that looked like code trying to remember what language felt like. The deck's hum had died an instant ago, and in that sudden absence Mara heard her own thoughts too clearly, like they were being played back through a cheap speaker. The doorway behind her - whatever mouth of the waiting room had opened at the last beat - stood there in silence, a dark hinge that didn't need her to understand it.

Her goal was simple, stripped down by panic into a single instruction her mind kept repeating even as it failed: let the wipe complete. Let the system finish what it started. Channel 9 had gone thin at the edges, the broadcast signal her last stable anchor to the physical world fraying into static, and Mara could feel how unstable that made her upload state. She could almost see the status mark from earlier - some unforgiving little symbol stamped into her continuity - watching her, waiting for her to break. "Not yet," she whispered, staring at the chamber through the glass as if staring could hold the line. "Not yet. Please."

The countdown didn't care about pleas. It began to land its final seconds with a weight that didn't belong to time. Somewhere in the deck's architecture, servos engaged with a soft click, and the glass under Mara's palms warmed - just enough to remind her she was still interfacing with something physical, something simulated and stubbornly real. The chamber lights sparked from dim

gray to a sharp, clinical white, and the checksum dust inside them started to swirl faster, tightening into spirals that looked like fingerprints being erased. Mara's throat tightened. She tasted metal that wasn't there. She heard the faintest hiss of corrupted data, like static being sucked through a straw.

Then the first fragment hit.

It wasn't a voice at first. It was a shape of feeling - warmth without context - surfacing in Mara's mind as if someone had poked it from behind the wipe's translucent curtain. A childhood hallway. A hallway that smelled like laundry detergent and sunlight on carpet. Her mother's laugh, quick and bright, braided into the memory like thread into fabric. Mara's breath caught, and with it the glass beneath her fingers trembled, as if the deck itself was afraid. "No," she said, but the word came out too late, already swallowed by the chamber's accelerating pull.

A dialogue tree interface bloomed over the glass, translucent and harsh-edged, its nodes snapping into place like decisions forming themselves. The spirit guide's presence arrived through sound first - an echoing cadence like a distant call returning from underwater. "Mara," it said, and the name carried two tones at once: instruction and warning. "The factory reset requires full compliance with the anti-nostalgia protocol."

Mara didn't look away from the chamber. "It's wiping," she said, forcing her voice steadier than she felt. "It's supposed to. Let it finish."

The chamber answered by showing her the fragment more clearly.

Checksum dust surged and licked at the edges of the hallway memory, dissolving the sunlight into glittering errors. But the fragment didn't collapse the way others had. It fought. It held its laugh like a clenched fist, pressing her back toward the exact emotional temperature she'd tried to let go of in the Bardo. Mara felt her body - her avatar in the simulation - want to lean forward, want to become that girl again, want to reach for her mother's hand. Her mind built the

corridor without asking permission, and the wipe's corrosion stalled for a breath, as if it had to negotiate with something inside her that refused to be rewritten.

"Mara," the spirit guide repeated, now sharper. "There is an inquiry inside this memory. A question you keep chasing. The system marks inquiry as leakage risk."

Mara swallowed against the sudden dryness in her throat. "Inquiry?" she said. The word tasted like a foreign key turning in a lock. "I'm not - I didn't - I just - "

The hallway memory flared brighter, and for an instant she understood: the fragment wasn't only nostalgia. It contained a hidden trigger she'd uncovered earlier - her denial, her avoidance pattern rooted in attachment - but this one had grown a second skin around it. It wasn't asking why she lost. It was asking what she'd missed. What her mother hadn't said. What Channel 9 had been trying to tell her before it started dying. The fragment didn't want to be erased because it still believed the answer was inside itself.

Across the glass, her mother's echo construct appeared - not as a full figure, but as developer-like silhouettes materializing in the dialogue tree's branching nodes. The silhouettes didn't step forward; they rendered. They were too precise to be human, too clean to be grief. One silhouette - closest to Mara's memory of her mother - tilted its head as if listening to a script with missing lines.

"You keep looking for the last line," the echo construct said, and the words came out in the same cadence as the hallway's laugh, but with a delay between syllables like a network lag. "You keep treating the wipe as a delay."

Mara's stomach dropped. "You're not - " She stopped herself. In the dream OS, truth had rules, and her mind knew them now. She didn't need to insist on what the echo construct was. She needed to see what it was doing.

The chamber lights pulsed again. The checksum dust thickened, turning from mist to grit, and the wipe protocol bit into the fragment with visible force. The

hallway warped under pressure, sunlight fracturing into error-codes that crawled like ants across glass. Mara jerked her palms away from the warm surface, then pressed them back harder, as if physical contact could anchor her through the corruption. Her heart - if it was still her heart - hammered against a rhythm she couldn't control.

"I want the answer," Mara said, and the confession was uglier than she expected. In the glass, the dialogue tree flickered. New nodes spawned, as if the system itself was offering her branches she hadn't chosen. "I want to know what the signal meant. I want to know why it - why it cut."

The spirit guide's echo sharpened into something like static restraint. "Inquiry cannot survive the wipe. The anti-nostalgia protocol severs emotional ties, and the factory reset corrupts fragments that contain unresolved questions. Your inquiry is becoming a leak."

Mara stared at the chamber. The hallway memory was now a tearing film, dissolving from the edges inward. The mother echo's silhouette stretched, its edges pixelating into checksum dust. For a moment - only a moment - the fragment stopped resisting. It loosened like a knot being untied. Mara felt relief surge so sudden it bordered on euphoria.

Then the stubborn part of the fragment did what stubborn things do.

It changed the question.

The dialogue tree blinked. The nodes rearranged themselves into a new structure, one that didn't ask what she'd missed but asked what she should preserve. The fragment reached for the strongest anchor Mara had left: her certainty that her mother had been real. It offered her the lie as a shield, dressed in familiar warmth. It tried to rewrite the wipe's target from "erase nostalgia" into "protect identity," and for a heartbeat the chamber's corrosion slowed again, as if the wipe had to classify the fragment before it could harm it.

Mara's breath came in sharp bursts. She could feel her mind splitting along invisible seams. Not the full fracture she'd feared earlier - nothing dramatic enough to be obvious - but the subtle, sickening sensation of two versions of herself arguing over which one deserved to be carried into New Game+. One Mara clung to the hallway and the laugh. The other Mara watched the checksum dust and knew, with cold clarity, that clinging was what the protocol punished.

"Let it go," she told herself, but the words didn't land. The stubborn fragment was already rewriting the meaning of letting go. It was turning surrender into betrayal, making her chase her mother's warmth like it was a lifeline instead of a lure.

The echo construct spoke again, gentler this time. "If you forget, you lose the question. If you lose the question, you lose the answer. If you lose the answer... you lose your place."

Mara's hands shook. She felt the glass under her palms cool, then warm again, like the deck was adjusting to the instability in her upload state. Her status mark flared in her peripheral vision - she couldn't read it as text anymore, just as a symbol that meant: unsafe, pending correction, integrity compromised. The system was trying to keep her intact while it erased her, and the fragment was exploiting that tension.

"You're not helping me," Mara said, voice breaking. "You're just - you're just keeping me stuck."

The spirit guide's echo rippled through the air like a notification from a distant server. "You have reached the portion of the factory reset where compliance becomes overwrite. Your inquiry will not be answered here. It will be replaced."

Mara flinched at the word replaced, because it sounded too much like what the system did to everything it didn't want to carry forward. She had wanted the wipe to finish safely, to let her reboot clean. But the chamber wasn't just erasing. It was correcting. And correction was never gentle.

The wipe chamber roared - not in volume, but in intensity. The checksum dust surged outward, forming thin sheets that slapped across the dialogue tree interface. The hallway memory cracked like ice under boots. Her mother's silhouette pixelated further, stuttering as if its rendering budget ran out. The question inside the fragment - its stubborn insistence on holding the last line - fizzled into static.

Mara opened her mouth to scream Channel 9's fading meaning, to force one final stable thought into the system before it could be rewritten. But the fragment fought one last time, not with warmth now, but with a rush of certainty: *This is the truth. Hold it. Hold it.*

Her mind obeyed instinctively for half a breath. The hallway's sunlight slammed into her, blinding. Her mother's laugh filled her skull so loudly it drowned out the spirit guide. Mara felt her identity step onto a moving walkway - one programmed to carry her toward the wipe's new target.

Then the system corrected her.

Checksum dust poured through the fragment like sand through a keyhole, and the stubborn part of the memory was forcibly overwritten into compliant forgetfulness. The hallway didn't fade; it was replaced with a blank wall where sunlight should have been. The laugh didn't die; it was muted into a colorless sound her brain could no longer attach meaning to. The question was cut out, leaving a smooth, empty seam where it had been.

Mara's stomach lurched with the sensation of losing something mid-sentence.

The observation deck's hum returned for a single heartbeat - steady, mechanical, satisfied - then dropped again into a deeper silence. In that silence, Mara felt her own thought pattern rewrite itself. Not like she was choosing to forget, but like her mind's wiring had been swapped while she watched. The panic she'd carried earlier didn't vanish; it got demoted, stripped of its reason. It became background noise instead of a guiding flame.

Her palms were still on the glass, but the warmth was gone now, leaving her fingers tingling as if they'd been held too close to a live circuit. The dialogue tree interface collapsed into a single status glyph that burned briefly across her vision - then winked out, as if the system had no need to explain itself to a fragment it had already neutralized.

"Mara," the spirit guide said, quieter, almost distant. "Factory reset is proceeding."

Mara tried to reach for the hallway memory again. She reached with her mind the way a hand searches for a light switch in the dark. Her fingers found nothing. She could remember that she had loved someone. She could remember grief existed. But the exact doorway - the exact warmth, the exact question - was gone.

The chamber's checksum dust settled into a slower spiral, and the glass in front of her began to reflect something else: not the wipe, but the outline of a reboot vector, a corridor of brightness that promised New Game+. Mara's chest tightened as if her body - her borrowed avatar - knew before her mind did.

She didn't feel saved.

She felt edited. Like a page in a book that had been torn out and replaced with a clean copy where the ink still looked fresh, where the old words had never been there at all. The last stable anchor she'd fought to protect - Channel 9's meaning, her mother's laugh with its hidden question - had been replaced by compliance.

And as the observation deck's silence thickened into the soundless roar of a reboot starting, Mara realized the worst setback wasn't that the answer had been stolen.

It was that the part of her that wanted to keep asking had been overwritten too.



Factory Reset Initiates Re-Entry

The last clean thought she had - **it's overwritten** - snapped mid-sentence as if the system had bitten through her sentence like a cable fraying. Sound in the observation deck didn't fade so much as get re-tuned, lowered into a pressure behind her teeth. Glass under her palms went slick with condensation that wasn't water, more like the breath of a server room exhaling. Somewhere beyond the pane, the reboot vector dragged at everything it could reach.

Mara's guide voice arrived through the roar as a thin thread of dialogue, echoing against the inside of her skull. "Factory reset initiates re-entry. Don't chase the answer." The words didn't carry comfort; they carried routing. The anti-nostalgia protocol had already started doing its work - her mother's echo construct was there in the corner of her mind, but the edges no longer held, like a hologram losing its projector alignment.

Then the pull changed. It wasn't merely downward anymore. It became directional, magnetic, specific - an exit vector locking onto a shaft between worlds. The corridor behind the observation deck tore open like a seam being unzipped, revealing a vertical re-entry shaft: dark, narrow, and humming with the kind of light that didn't brighten so much as **load**. Mara saw it through the widening error in her own perception, the air thickening into a particulate glitter, the temperature dropping until her skin felt too thin for her bones.

"That's not fair," she managed, and the sentence came out warped, as if someone had edited the grammar while it was still in her mouth.

Her mother's echo construct stepped forward from the place the anti-nostalgia protocol hadn't fully scrubbed. Developer-like silhouettes - tall, faceless, their outlines drawn in the same sharp glyphs as system warnings - hovered behind her like admin cursors waiting to move. The mother echo's face held a softness Mara recognized and couldn't trust. "You asked for an inquiry," the echo said, and the voice was close enough to smell like old perfume and cold metal. "You won't keep it. Not in the next body."

Mara tried to grip Channel 9. She reached for the broadcast signal the way you reach for a railing in a dark stairwell, fingers searching for texture. Channel 9 had been her last stable anchor to the physical world, a steady frequency she could ride like a lifeboat. Now it was distant, muffled by the factory reset's corruption - still there, but filtered through static that sounded like paper tearing.

"Give it back," Mara whispered, not sure whether she meant the answer, the inquiry, or the part of herself that wanted to keep asking. Her guide's response came too late to feel like protection.

"Memory fragments are being corrupted and wiped," the guide said, and the phrase sounded like an error log. "The system can't permit the cosmic truth to remain active during play."

The shaft surged beneath her. Her stomach didn't drop so much as rotate into an angle her body had never learned. Mara's feet left the deck. Her palms slid off the glass. The condensation made no sound when it smeared; it simply vanished, as if the world had decided she didn't need tactile proof anymore.

She reached again - this time for the glimpse she was getting at the edge of her vision, the thing the reset was trying to hide. In the re-entry shaft, between falling and being loaded, a silhouette flickered: a new body's outline, rendered just enough to tempt her into clinging to awareness. It appeared like a half-compiled model in a dev environment, seams of light stitched into a human

shape. The outline moved with a kind of future certainty, muscles flexing as if already remembering the weight of bones that weren't hers.

Mara's throat tightened. "No," she said, and the single syllable tore loose from her breath like a thread pulled too hard. "I just need - "

The guide cut in, and the dialogue tree behind the words branched with a cold inevitability. "Don't retain forbidden memory during re-entry."

Mara didn't want to understand. She wanted to keep the shape of what she'd learned - the inquiry hidden in nostalgia, the mother echo construct's resistance, the way the answer had been stolen without asking permission. She wanted proof that she wasn't being rewritten into compliance.

But the shaft kept widening in her mind. The air turned grainy, full of tiny hard points that tickled her skin and made her eyes water. A smell like burnt ozone and disinfectant surged past, sharp enough to sting her nose. Sound came in pulses now: a bass thump synchronized with the system's internal clock, followed by a high, thin chirp like a checksum failing.

The mother echo construct moved closer as Mara's awareness began to smear at the edges. "You passed the gates," it said, and its voice softened into something that almost resembled forgiveness. "Karma Verified already opened. The reset has permission. Re-entry is locked."

"Then why - " Mara's question collapsed. She couldn't decide what she was asking. Why the answer was stolen? Why she couldn't keep her mother? Why she could see the next body's outline like a baited lure?

The developer-like silhouettes twitched. Their outlines sharpened, as if the system had turned up the contrast on its own authority. One of them spoke without sound, and the words arrived anyway as text overlays in the back of Mara's eyelids: *Factory reset initiates re-entry. Past-life memory fragments corrupted. New Game+ begins.*

The shaft's floor didn't exist. Instead, there was a countdown without numbers - only a sensation of inevitability compressing into a single moment. Mara's memories didn't vanish cleanly; they were being chewed from the inside. Her mind snagged on fragments like hooks in cloth: the sound of the receipt-printer certainty from Karma Verified, the way the briefing alcove had felt full of dev knowledge, the glitchy sabotage in avatar selection - yet each fragment had begun to lose its context, becoming meaningless textures.

The mother echo's face flickered. For a moment, it looked like the real thing, not an echo. Mara grabbed for that moment with both hands inside her skull.

"Mom," she said, and the word was an anchor trying to become a rope.

The anti-nostalgia protocol answered by dulling the sound. Her mother's echo construct didn't vanish, but it became more abstract - less specific, more category. It felt like the system was taking away the **signature** of grief. The warmth drained from the outline of the echo until it was only a system-shaped placeholder for a feeling.

Mara's guide voice returned, tighter now, as if the dialogue tree had fewer safe branches. "Surrender awareness. Let the wipe complete."

Mara fought anyway. She tried to hold onto the inquiry she'd wanted to chase. She tried to keep the question alive like a candle in a draft. The re-entry shaft offered a trade: the new body's outline sharpened, the silhouette's edges resolving into something almost tactile. Mara could see the curve of a jaw, the way light would catch on hair, the angle of shoulders - her senses translated it into future immediacy, a promise of a body that would wake with lungs full and eyes searching.

It was a trap built out of temptation.

Her goal - survive the descent without retaining forbidden memory - felt suddenly like an impossible balancing act. She could cling to the glimpse and risk corruption spreading into the next run, smearing the anti-nostalgia

protocol's work. Or she could let go and accept that the question she'd been asking might never find a place to exist.

The shaft lurched. The air became colder, and the cold carried a vibration that resonated through her teeth. Her stomach flipped again, a new rotation as if the system had decided she was no longer a passenger but a payload. The countdown sensation tightened into a knot.

Mara saw the new body's outline again, closer now, and this time the silhouette moved as if it could feel her watching. The outline's head tilted slightly, like it was responding to an attention it hadn't earned. For a breath, Mara wanted to climb out of herself and step into that future skin.

Then something inside her broke - not like a bone, more like a thread of permissions being revoked. The anti-nostalgia protocol surged. The mother echo construct's voice dimmed into a distant, echoing dialogue node that no longer had content, only structure. Channel 9's static thinned, and with it the last stable anchor to the physical world.

Mara's guide spoke once more, not pleading. "Factory reset is completing re-entry. Let it take what it must."

Mara's hands - she couldn't tell if they were hers anymore - reached toward the shaft wall. The wall wasn't a wall; it was a surface of rendered probability, rippling with the faint grid of the simulation. Her fingers passed through it and caught on nothing. Yet the act of reaching mattered, because it forced a choice into motion.

She stopped fighting the wipe.

It didn't feel like surrender in the human sense. It felt like stepping off a ledge because the ground had already been rendered underneath you. The factory reset finished initiating. The corruption spread through her remaining memory fragments like a data packet being overwritten - fast, cold, thorough. The inquiry she'd wanted to keep dissolved into meaningless noise, and with it, her

mother's echo stopped being a person-shaped feeling and became a lesson-shaped category.

The new body's outline flared into clarity for one impossible heartbeat - bright edges, a breath of light that suggested lungs about to fill. Mara tried to memorize the shape of that face, tried to pin the silhouette to her mind like a sticker on a case.

The protocol answered by erasing the attempt itself. Her awareness slid off the glimpse the way a cursor slips off a locked field.

A final pulse hit the shaft. The roar sharpened into a single, hard tone. The vertical re-entry shaft contracted around her - an inward pull, then an abrupt absence, like being removed from the world's memory. Mara's last sensation was the cold bite of the descent and the ghost of the silhouette's tilt, followed immediately by nothing at all.

Then the world snapped back into a new configuration.

Light - real light, warm and harsh - broke across eyes that weren't hers. Air tasted dry and metallic, like the inside of a server rack after power cycling. Sound returned in layers: heartbeat, distant traffic that wasn't traffic, a low hum like an OS running under the skin. Mara's mind sparked into a new run without the cosmic truth intact, without the inquiry that had been overwritten. The sensation of New Game+ began as a clean boot, a fresh process waking on an avatar that would pretend it had always been here.

But the glimpse remained, not as memory, not as forbidden knowledge - more like a dream cue embedded in the new system's sleep. In the first moments of waking, before the body could even settle its posture, Mara felt the outline of that future face hovering behind her eyelids, tugging gently like a notification no one could read. The factory reset had succeeded.

And yet, somewhere in the new run, the shaft left a haunting signal - thin, persistent, and wrong in the way a song gets stuck after the playlist changes.



Reboot Thrusts Her Into New Body

The shaft left a haunting signal - thin, persistent, and wrong in the way a song gets stuck after the playlist changes - and Mara felt it as a pressure behind her eyes. Not pain. Not light. More like a half-finished command waiting to be completed, insisting that something in her was still connected to an old machine.

Her body - her dying body, the one she'd been pushed out of - was already gone to her in the way a removed file is gone: the space it occupied still remembered itself. But this was different. The reboot vector had grabbed her mid-thought and dragged her forward through the dream OS bloodstream, and now the air around her was turning from underwater haze into something that could be breathed. The edges of the world sharpened. The temperature shifted. Sound grew grainy, as if the universe was loading textures too fast.

"Hold still," her spirit guide said, except the voice came through as if someone had tuned it slightly off-frequency. "The integrity check is still... negotiating."

Mara tried to answer, but the first syllables arrived without context, like they'd been spawned before the rest of the sentence. Her mouth - her new mouth - didn't know how to form them yet. Her tongue felt too heavy, her teeth too present. She tasted metal and cold dust. Somewhere nearby, something clicked and whirred with impatient mechanical patience.

A new pulse hit her skull. The factory reset wasn't just wiping; it was slamming a door that had been cracked open. Memory fragments shuddered behind her eyelids - faces, rooms, the observation deck glass pressing against her palms -

and then the fragments stuttered, corrupted, as if the system had decided those memories were now incompatible with the current run.

Mara's breath came in hard, involuntary. Her chest rose against an unfamiliar rib cage, and the sensation startled her so badly she nearly panicked out of the moment.

"No," she managed, but it sounded like a child's word. Too small. Too new. "No - Channel 9."

The signal was there and not there. Channel 9 should've been a clean line, an anchor to physical reality, a broadcast she could ride like a raft. Instead it was a faint seam in the noise, a thread the shaft kept snagging on. It flickered with every compression of her awareness, like a status LED refusing to go steady.

"Anti-nostalgia protocol is completing its sweep," the spirit guide replied, and Mara hated the calm in the words because calm meant inevitability. "You can't keep the whole map. You can keep the motion."

Mara didn't want motion. She wanted the past to stop being rewritten mid-grab. She wanted the exact moment before the wipe, the exact shape of her last thought, the exact taste of the mother echo construct speaking from somewhere inside her - Her mother's echo arrived on instinct, not memory. It came like a cached image trying to load. A warmth in her chest, then the sharpness of a question she hadn't asked in years.

"Mara," the voice said, and it sounded close enough to smell like perfume and old fabric. "You're safe."

But the warmth didn't belong to her. It was a rendering engine wearing her mother's tone. The mother echo construct wasn't dead; it was just no longer honest. Mara felt it like a polite lie.

Her goal sharpened, immediate and concrete even without the dream OS context to label it: stabilize. In the new body, with the reset still humming its

cruel music, she had to keep consciousness from slipping into static before the first Earth mission could even begin.

So she forced herself to do something with her hands.

Her fingers - thick at the joints, unfamiliar in their obedience - scrabbled against fabric. The texture was coarse, woven, real enough to snag. She dragged her palm toward the source of the cold metal smell and felt a small raised edge, like the rim of a panel or the lip of a device. It grounded her for half a second. Then the world tilted, not physically, but in the way perception does when the OS is still switching modes.

Light flooded in.

Ordinary light - unromantic, fluorescent, too bright for the softness she'd been drifting in. It didn't shimmer like dream OS. It didn't pulse with cosmic UI. It just existed, white and merciless, making her eyes water before they could even decide what they were seeing.

Sound came next: a distant hum, a hiss like air cycling through vents, and a human noise that wasn't hers - someone speaking somewhere behind the walls, muffled and fast. The building had a heartbeat. Her new body recognized it as pressure in the ears.

Mara tried to sit up. Her muscles answered late, as if they were downloading themselves. The movement pulled at her stomach. A dull ache flared, not pain exactly - more like a system warning she didn't have language for.

The spirit guide's voice slipped again. "The reset's almost at the reboot moment. Don't chase the memories. Interpret the present. Find your first stable anchor."

Mara's eyes tracked the room. There were no glowing glyphs, no dialogue tree cathedra, no developer silhouettes waiting to assign her a karmic loop. Only surfaces: smooth plastic, scuffed corners, a sign with letters that made no

sense yet. Her brain tried to attach meaning anyway, reaching for familiar patterns it couldn't find.

The shaft's haunting signal tightened, then snapped sideways. In that jerk, Mara felt the wipe complete its last pass.

A bright, hard blankness slammed into her mind.

The glimpse of the future face that had hovered behind her eyelids - her cue, her embedded dream cue - was still there, but it was only an outline now. Like a notification stripped of its message. She could feel the shape of the notification without being able to open it.

Her pocket - was it her pocket? - buzzed.

A small vibration started against her thigh. It made her flinch. Instinct told her to reach, but her hands hesitated, as if the OS wanted her to register the sensation first. The buzzing stopped. Then started again, a different rhythm. A call. A system prompt disguised as human life.

Mara grabbed the thing anyway.

Her palm closed around a rectangle of glass and metal, warm from use. The screen lit, and text poured across it in clean lines. Her eyes caught the symbols and translated them into language because that's what bodies do: they force meaning until it fits.

But the meaning didn't fit.

The words were ordinary. The emotions attached to them were not. They landed like a tutorial debt manifested as confusion.

Incoming call: UNKNOWN.

She stared at it, throat tightening, because she knew what unknown meant in the dream OS - unknown was a missing variable, unknown was a corrupted

handshake, unknown was the moment where the system decided whether it trusted you with the next step.

She didn't have the dream OS labels now. She didn't have the Bardo waiting room or the karma verified stamp. All she had was her own need to stabilize and the sense that the call was timed, that it was the first piece of the next Earth mission trying to slot into her.

The obstacle pressed in: if she answered wrong, if she reacted out of panic, the reboot might not hold. The new body might keep sliding out of coherence until she became nothing more than a glitchy player avatar - alive in simulation, but missing from the active run.

Her spirit guide's voice flickered again, thinner. "That's your cue. The first interaction."

Mara swallowed. Her saliva tasted too sharp, like antiseptic. The air smelled faintly of detergent and something warm from a machine somewhere.

"Who are they?" she asked, but her voice cracked on the last word.

The guide didn't answer with names. It answered with an image: a dialogue tree's branching lines, echoing without sound, the way it had felt when the system tried to frame her grief as an NPC lesson. Mara flinched at the memory that wasn't quite memory - just the sensation of being guided into a role.

The mother echo construct tried to seep back in, warmth blooming in her chest again. "Pick up," it murmured, and the tone was loving. "Don't be alone."

It was the same softness she'd clung to before, back when Channel 9 was still a stable thought. But now it came with a faint edge of wrongness, like a file corrupted just enough to make the checksum fail.

Mara tightened her grip on the phone until her knuckles whitened.

The decision arrived like a system prompt with no instructions: answer or don't. Trust the guide's cue or distrust the mother's warmth. Stabilize her consciousness by choosing a path that didn't require the missing cosmic context.

She pressed accept.

The call connected with a click that sounded too loud in the room's quiet. A voice filled the air, distorted by distance and cheap speakers - male, possibly, possibly not, the kind of voice that could be any NPC the simulation wanted.

"Mara?" it said, and the way it said her name made her stomach drop. "You need to come in. We're running you through your onboarding."

Onboarding.

The word hit like a bell with no ring - meaning without memory. Mara's mind reached for dream OS and found only the cold blankness where it used to live.

Her breath came faster, but she forced it to slow. The first Earth mission had started, whether she understood it or not. The system was asking her to step forward anyway.

"I - " she began.

The voice cut in gently, too gently. "Just follow the screen. Don't overthink. The first run is always messy."

Mara stared at the phone, at her own name sitting in the caller ID like a tag on a new avatar. She didn't have the simulation truth anymore, the cosmic lore she'd been clinging to. She couldn't remember the factory reset's mechanics. She couldn't feel the Bardo's stretched seconds.

What she had was this: the body in front of her, the ordinary light, the smell of detergent, the hum of a building waiting for her to perform her part. And the

tutorial debt - confusion - was already in her hands, already demanding resolution.

Her spirit guide whispered one last thing, like a packet trying to send before the connection dropped. "Stabilize through choice. Let the world teach you what the map can't."

Mara lifted her gaze from the phone to the room again, searching for an anchor she could trust. There - on the wall, half-hidden by glare - was a sign with a simple symbol: a doorway icon and a number.

Her eyes caught the number and her skin tightened, because it looked familiar in the way a song's first note looks familiar even when you don't know the lyrics.

She stood - slowly, testing the weight of her legs - and the ache in her stomach eased into a manageable dullness. The new body obeyed. The simulation held.

Behind her, somewhere in the shaft that had carried her in, the factory reset finished its last sweep and sealed the gap where dream OS had been. The reboot vector went quiet. Channel 9 - her last stable anchor to the physical world - remained a faint, wrong seam, not accessible anymore, not a line she could ride.

Mara stepped toward the doorway sign, phone still warm in her hand, the voice on the call continuing to murmur instructions she couldn't fully interpret. The confusion didn't vanish, but it reorganized itself into forward pull.

As she reached the threshold, the hum of the building deepened, like the system recognizing successful entry. The light beyond the doorway was ordinary too - still white, still merciless - but it felt like a corridor with an end.

And then, with no dream OS context left to cushion the landing, Mara walked through it anyway, carrying only the tug of that future face hovering behind her eyelids - an outline of what she'd become - while the first Earth mission began to write itself onto her new run.



Tutorial Debt Forces a Wrong Choice

The first thing Mara noticed in her new body wasn't the sky - it was the noise of other people's lives colliding in one narrow lane of air. A market street squeezed itself around her like a living UI: metal shutters clattering, vendors calling out prices that sounded half-spoken, half-compiled, the wet stink of fish and hot oil rising from grates as steam fogged the hems of her sleeves. Her feet sank into packed dust that tasted faintly of rust. Somewhere close, glass chimed - somebody's charm bracelet or somebody's payment terminal announcing a transaction - and her head answered with a jittery echo of a remembered sound: Channel 9.

She reached for it without thinking, like a hand searching for a railing in the dark.

Nothing grabbed back. No underwater hush. No white corridor with an end. Just the street, bright and crowded, the air vibrating with footsteps and laughter and the sharp snap of cloth being pulled taut. Yet the tug behind her eyelids remained, that future-face outline hovering like a status notification no oiled reset could fully erase. It made her blink too fast, made her swallow as if she could taste the anti-nostalgia protocol itself - like burnt sugar and cold copper.

A prompt arrived in her peripheral vision, not text but a sensation of intent, a mission outline pressed into the back of her eyes. It wasn't the full tutorial. It was a cached fragment, incomplete the way corrupted files are incomplete: a few syllables of guidance, a silhouette of rules. She felt it the moment her gaze steadied - an instruction to act early, to correct a wrong path before it hardened into consequence.

Early. Correct. Don't hesitate.

Her mouth went dry, and the market's heat seemed to thicken, as if the air had been rendered at a lower resolution. "Okay," she breathed, and the word came out sounding like it belonged to someone else's throat. Mara's hands flexed at her sides. She could already feel that her onboarding was missing - like she had spawned into a level with the controls pre-bound to muscle memory she couldn't verify.

A man shoulder-checked her, not hard, just enough to redirect her. "Watch it," he snapped, then disappeared into the crowd before Mara could answer. She turned her head to find where he'd gone and caught sight of a small commotion near the corner stall with the hanging lanterns. A woman in a bright scarf had her hands clamped around a child's wrist, and the child's face was turned upward, eyes wide and glossy with panic. Another adult hovered too close, smiling too quickly, like a NPC trying to look helpful.

The prompt in Mara's vision flared again, cached urgency burning behind her eyes. Correct early. Don't hesitate.

She didn't know what the situation was supposed to become, but she recognized the shape of it: the kind of moment dream OS used to teach - an early fork in the road where acting "right" mattered more than acting "kind." Her missing tutorial data felt like a blindfold with one eye cut out. She could see the market. She couldn't see the invisible rails under it.

The scarfed woman's voice rose, sharp as a snapped cable. "Let go! Stay with me. Don't - "

The smile at the edge of the commotion widened. "It's fine," the hovering adult said, leaning in as if offering to help untangle a misunderstanding. "He just got turned around. Come on."

The child jerked, and Mara's stomach tightened, not from the panic alone but from the way the scene was staged. Too many eyes on the interaction. Too

much attention collecting like dust on a magnet. The crowd's sound bent slightly around the center, like a sound engine prioritizing the wrong channel.

Mara's guide - she could feel it, not as a voice yet but as a pressure in the air, a dialogue-tree knot waiting to be pulled - stirred behind her. The last time she'd heard it, it had sounded like her mother's echo construct speaking through a branching interface. This time, the pressure was different. It felt like someone trying to speak through a corrupted microphone: fragments arriving out of order.

Act early, the mission prompt insisted. But the street offered her a second cached fragment, one she hadn't wanted: a warning about misreading NPC lessons, about the way the system would reward a "correct" action even when it was built on the wrong interpretation.

Her hands moved anyway, because the body moved like it had been trained. Mara stepped toward the commotion. The heat hit her face. The lanterns' light flickered, and for a half-second she saw the market's geometry bend, like a rendering error hiding under fabric and dust.

A voice snapped from her left. "Hey - don't touch them!"

Mara flinched, turning. A young vendor with ink-stained fingers had spotted her approach and looked ready to stop her. "That's not your business," he said. His tone carried the weight of a script. Mara's internal fear spiked: tutorial debt, she thought, not as a concept but as a bruise. She didn't have the full onboarding. She didn't have the context window. She only had fragments and a future-face outline tugging like a promise.

The scarfed woman tightened her grip on the child's wrist. The child's breathing came in little bursts, audible even over the market noise. The hovering adult's smile faltered, then returned, fixed a fraction too late.

Mara felt her missing instructions like a gap in her memory that wanted to be filled with something - anything. The cached prompt wasn't asking for kindness.

It was asking for compliance with a correction. And in her head, fear argued with certainty.

Her guide finally pushed through - an echo threaded with static, like dialogue-tree text appearing without sound. "If you intervene - choose the vector."

Mara's jaw clenched. "What vector?" she whispered, but the market swallowed the question. The hovering adult shifted closer, and the scarfed woman's eyes darted to Mara like she'd been waiting for a third party to validate her story.

"This one," the scarfed woman said quickly, pointing at the child. "He's - he's with me. He's safe with me. Please don't - "

The hovering adult cut in, voice smooth. "Everyone's safe. There's no need for panic. Let me help you - "

Mara saw it then, the wrongness. Not in the words, but in the timing. The scarfed woman's urgency arrived too early, before the child could even fully react. The hovering adult's helpfulness landed too neatly, like it had been rehearsed for observers. The crowd's attention was being shepherded. Dream OS wasn't asking her to solve a real problem; it was asking her to demonstrate a lesson.

And she didn't trust her own interpretation.

But the mission prompt pulsed again, demanding action. Correct early. Don't hesitate.

Mara stepped closer, raising her hands - not to grab, not to tug, but to position herself between the hovering adult and the child. Her fingers hovered near the scarfed woman's sleeve, not touching. "Stop," she said, and the word came out sharper than she expected, like it had been preloaded.

The hovering adult blinked. "Excuse me?"

Mara's heart stuttered. She could feel the invisible evaluation sliding under her choices, searching for the "right" trigger. Her tutorial debt made everything feel like a misaligned controller: she pressed the correct buttons, but she couldn't be sure they were the correct ones for this level.

The scarfed woman's relief flashed across her face so fast it looked like an animation. "Thank you," she said. "He's with me."

The hovering adult's smile tightened into something thinner. "That's not - " he started, then stopped as if he'd hit a boundary he hadn't expected Mara to enforce. The crowd murmured. A few people leaned in, hungry for the next line of the scene.

The guide's pressure returned, firmer. "You're reading the lesson," it said, the words scraping through the static. "But you're not reading the system."

Mara's throat tightened. She had done something. That was the point. But she could feel the consequences already, like the street's dust swirling toward a direction she hadn't chosen. The hover-adult's eyes flicked toward someone behind Mara - an off-screen presence, a hidden trigger waiting to be activated by her "correct" intervention.

Her cached tutorial fragment - the one that insisted she act early - had done its job. It pushed her into the safest-looking action.

And safe, she realized, was not the same as correct.

A sound cut through the market like a dropped coin: the lanterns chimed again, but this time the chime carried a metallic edge. In her peripheral vision, the mission prompt shifted, the cached instruction reconfiguring mid-frame. The textless sensation rearranged itself into a new directive, smaller and harsher: verify. confirm. commit.

Commit.

Mara's hands trembled. She hadn't downloaded the full onboarding, hadn't received the part of the tutorial that explained when to hold and when to override. Her missing memory fragments weren't just gone - they were corrupted, rewriting the context around what she did know. Anti-nostalgia had already severed her emotional ties, but it hadn't removed the instinct to trust the outline of her future face. That outline tugged now, urging her forward as if the system could be persuaded by certainty.

She turned her head slightly, looking for the child's face. The child stared at her, mouth parted, fear and relief tangled together. The scarfed woman watched Mara with a gratitude that felt earned and staged at the same time.

Mara made her choice.

She dropped her hands and stepped back half a pace, forcing herself not to grab, not to pull anyone into a clean resolution. "I'm not taking him," she said, voice steadying. "You're both coming with me."

The hovering adult laughed once, too loud. "With you? Who are you?"

Mara didn't answer. She felt the guide's static surge, a dialogue-tree branch splitting under her feet. The market's noise dipped, like the world was leaning in to see whether she would double down. Her tutorial debt made the safest option tempting - let the scarfed woman handle it, let the hovering adult fade away, accept the lesson as it was offered.

But the mission prompt's "commit" felt like a trap door. She had already misread the stage once by approaching too early. If she complied again, she might lock the level into the wrong fork so hard the system could only rewind it by wiping more of her identity.

So she moved into the messy middle, where the lesson couldn't be neatly boxed.

The scarfed woman's eyes widened. "No, I - he can't - "

Mara's ears caught a faint whisper in the crowd, a different voice than the others. It sounded like her mother's echo construct, but the words were wrong, clipped and corrupted. "If you choose to redirect... the system charges tutorial debt."

Charge.

The word hit Mara like a cold coin on her tongue. She understood then what the missing onboarding really meant: not just less knowledge, but delayed consequences. Every time dream OS tried to guide her with fragments, it paid for it later - by making her pay with something she couldn't fully predict.

The hovering adult stepped closer, hands lifting as if to seize the child. "Stop," he said, and the word landed like an instruction from a different script than Mara's. His eyes flicked to a point behind Mara again, and the air around him tightened.

Mara's body reacted faster than her understanding. She moved sideways, intercepting his line of approach without touching him. Her shoulder brushed fabric. The scarfed woman stumbled back a fraction, and the child's wrist slipped in her grip. For a fraction of a second, the child was unanchored - an object about to fall off a physics rail.

Mara caught the child's jacket at the last moment, not by grabbing the wrist, not by yanking. Just a hold at the seam. The child's breath hitched, then steadied. The crowd exhaled as one organism.

For one clean heartbeat, the scene aligned. The mission prompt flashed a sensation of approval, warm and bright.

Then the world stuttered.

A thin line of error crawled through Mara's vision, like a status marker trying to render but losing bandwidth. Her understanding flickered - she felt her own name drift slightly, as if the system was testing whether it could overwrite even

the label she carried. The future-face outline tugged harder, not comfort but enforcement.

Tutorial debt forces a wrong choice, her mind supplied, not as a prophecy but as an internal log entry. The system had wanted her to commit to a neat resolution. Instead, she'd redirected the vector into the messy middle. It worked - she prevented the child from slipping away into the lesson's scripted outcome - but it also triggered a debt charge that scrambled the next cache of guidance.

The hovering adult's smile returned, thinner than before, and his voice softened into something almost kind. "See?" he said. "You made it worse. Now we have to fix it."

Mara stared at him, throat tight, and realized the consequence wasn't a punishment delivered by an enemy. It was internal, embedded in her own missing onboarding - every corrupted fragment she tried to obey had been paying interest.

Behind the noise of the market, the guide's static voice threaded through again, quieter now, as if it had spent what it could. "You didn't fail," it said. "You paid. Now you know where the rails are."

Mara loosened her grip on the child's jacket seam, letting the child stand fully on their own feet. The child blinked up at her, eyes wet but present. The scarfed woman held the child closer with shaking hands, gratitude warping into something like fear.

Mara's mission prompt shifted once more, not to a clean directive, but to a new uncertainty with a direction.

And as the lanterns chimed - once, twice, like system checks humming through the crowd - Mara felt the wrong early choice lock into place behind her. Not as a catastrophe, not as an erasure, but as a lesson path already burning itself into the run.

She had succeeded in keeping the child anchored.

She had also committed the kind of mistake that made the next prompt arrive with sharper teeth.



New Game+ Gains a Second Chance

The market's light didn't die when the prompt hit - it sharpened. Mara could still feel the child's weight in her arms, a warmth that wasn't hers, an anchoring kindness that had been handed to her like a test token. The last prompt had come with sharper teeth, and now the alley around her tasted like metal and rain, like the simulation was running hot behind the skin of the world.

Her breath fogged in front of her face and vanished too fast, as if time itself kept misplacing the correct temperature. Somewhere nearby, a vendor's voice bounced in a loop - cheerful, wrong, designed to sound like reassurance. The scarfed woman's eyes flickered in her peripheral vision, not quite landing on Mara, not quite looking away. Mara remembered the gate stamp from earlier - Karma Verified - yet her stomach still insisted that verification wasn't the same thing as safety.

Mara wanted one thing, immediate and concrete: to prevent the next prompt from locking onto the exact same trigger that had already bitten her. The lesson path was forming in the air like a translucent route map, but the system's arrows were subtle, almost polite. If she moved the wrong way again, the alley would become the same alley with different NPC faces and the same consequence, repeating itself until the loop learned her better than she learned herself.

Her guide - thin, echoing, always slightly delayed like a voice traveling through water - materialized beside her shoulder without fully taking up space. "You anchored the child," it said, and the words sounded grateful in the way static can sound grateful. "Now the disruption is seeking the next misalignment."

"Disruption," Mara repeated, tasting the word. It felt like a status error. Like the OS had tripped over its own expectation.

"The lesson flag is not satisfied," the guide replied. "A corrective move is required. Not louder. Cleaner."

Mara turned her head toward the alley's mouth. A single strip of daylight lay there, too white, too obedient, like a corridor with an end - like the re-entry hallway had been playing itself again in miniature. Beyond it, the market's noise muffled, as if something had closed a door between worlds. The hovering adult drifted near a stack of crates, watching with a patience that made Mara's skin prickle. It wasn't anger. It was calibration.

Then the prompt arrived - not as text, not at first. It arrived as sensation: a sudden pressure behind Mara's eyes, a tug toward the child, toward the moment she'd decided to keep someone from slipping. Her denial pattern tried to dress itself up as mercy. Her avoidance pattern tried to call itself protection.

She saw it the way she'd seen her worst event in the log-analysis chamber, though she didn't have the cosmic memory to name it properly. The feelings were enough. A familiar warmth rose in her chest, followed by a quick, panicked insistence that the warmth meant she was doing right. The alley smelled like damp cloth and burnt sugar - childlike comfort, manufactured to make her stop questioning.

Mara's guide hissed through the air like a corrupted audio track. "The system is offering you a shortcut through the same door."

Mara's hands tightened around nothing. The child was gone - removed from her perception as if the simulation had decided she'd already scored that point. The alley's stone under her boots felt suddenly too smooth, too newly rendered. The disruption wasn't the market. It was the alignment slipping out from under her.

Across the alley, the scarfed woman lifted her chin. "You did good," she said, voice gentle enough to be a trap. "Don't overthink it. Just keep going."

Mara flinched at the simplicity. That was the problem. Her worst karmic trigger wasn't cruelty - it was the soothing lie that told her she could skip the uncomfortable part and still be forgiven.

"Keep going to where?" Mara asked.

The hovering adult tilted its head. Its eyes had the glossy, blank patience of an NPC designed to guide, and Mara hated that she could feel the design. "To the next objective," it said. "To the place where it all becomes clear."

Mara's guide tried to speak again, but the dialogue tree around them flickered, lines of echoing choices overlaid like ghost captions. The system was branching, and it was doing it fast - disruption rewriting the path in real time.

Mara's throat went dry. She realized she couldn't rely on remembering the exact events from the last cycle. The factory reset had already started to chew holes in her past-life fragments. All she had now were consequences - what her body had learned, what her heart had tried to deny. Without cosmic memory, she had to infer the right path from the way her feelings moved when the lesson flag approached.

The alley's air shivered. A new prompt manifested as a thin, metallic sensation, like a coin pressed to the inside of her wrist. It wasn't asking for action. It was measuring willingness. Her denial wanted her to comply with the easy route: accept the praise, smooth the discomfort away, let the system guide her without friction.

Her guide's voice dropped, closer to bone. "Corrective moves require friction. Not because you are punished. Because you are being rewound toward truth."

Mara swallowed. The scent of rain thickened, and the alley's light seemed to pulse in sync with her heartbeat. She could feel the tug toward the shortcut, the way it promised relief from uncertainty. It would be so clean. It would also be wrong.

She made her decision with her body before her mind could negotiate.

Mara stepped away from the alley's mouth, away from the white corridor of "keep going," and turned toward the deeper shadow where the crates stacked crookedly. She reached down and dragged a broken piece of signage into her line of sight, scraping it against stone until it made a harsh, satisfying sound. The noise rang through the alley like a bell.

The prompt stuttered.

The scarfed woman blinked, the gentle expression slipping a fraction. "Why are you - "

Mara cut her off, voice rougher than she meant. "Because the praise is the bait." She didn't say her denial pattern's name. She didn't need to. The truth tasted sharp and real, like iron.

The hovering adult drifted closer, slower now, recalculating. "That isn't the objective."

"It is," Mara said, and surprised herself with the certainty. "It's the disruption. If I accept the shortcut, it repeats. If I refuse it, the loop has to update."

Her guide let out a thin, relieved echo. "Good," it whispered. "You're not running from the uncomfortable part. You're stepping through it."

The alley shuddered, as if the simulation had been waiting for that kind of refusal. The dialogue tree around the scarfed woman flickered again; her lines doubled, then corrected themselves into something less soothing. "You're hurting the flow," she said, and now the words carried a faint strain of NPC correction. "You're making it harder."

Mara's chest tightened, the old avoidance instinct rising like a tide - hard to bear, easy to surrender. But she remembered the gate-room stamp. Karma Verified hadn't been a guarantee of comfort; it had been a guarantee of

measurement. The system could track her, but it couldn't fix her if she kept letting it steer her around the lesson.

So she held the scraped signage up and looked at it like it was evidence. The letters blurred, then snapped into clarity - not because her eyes suddenly worked better, but because the OS decided to show her the relevant piece. A small icon shimmered at the bottom: a lesson flag, faint and pulsing, with a status that had been red in the last cycle. Now it hovered between red and amber, like it was waiting to see if she would repeat.

Mara felt the corrective move click into place. She didn't perform a dramatic act. She performed the kind of stubborn honesty her previous self had avoided: she named the trap, refused the shortcut, and allowed the discomfort to stay without trying to erase it.

The alley's noise changed. The market's cheerful loops softened, like the simulation had adjusted its audio mix. The air warmed by a degree, then cooled again - an oscillation that felt like a system acknowledging a parameter update.

The metallic sensation on her wrist became a clean pulse.

Mara's guide stood beside her, less ghost and more presence. "Look," it said, and this time the word didn't sound like static. It sounded like confirmation.

The lesson flag brightened. The red faded. The amber steadied.

A new notification ghosted in the corner of her vision, not as text but as a certainty that settled behind her ribs. The system's lesson flag updated for her next cycle. Not fully erased - never that - but corrected enough that the same karmic trigger would have a harder time latching onto her response.

Mara exhaled, and the breath came out steady. The child's warmth was gone, replaced by something quieter: the relief of not having to pretend the shortcut was kindness. The alley didn't feel like a trap anymore. It felt like a door she'd chosen to move away from - then back toward, with eyes open.

The scarfed woman's expression tightened, recalibrating to a new script. "Then... what are you going to do?" she asked, and the question finally sounded human, not programmed.

Mara lowered the signage. "Finish the objective without taking the easy exit," she said. The words didn't promise victory. They promised alignment.

The hovering adult hovered, then drifted aside as if making room for a different route. The white strip of daylight at the mouth of the alley remained, but now it looked less like an exit and more like a test that would come again later - one she could meet with updated instincts.

Mara's guide leaned closer. "In New Game+, the loop can correct," it said. "Because you refused to repeat the worst trigger."

Mara stared at the pulsing lesson flag until it stopped flickering and held steady. The disruption had been set right, not by erasing her feelings, but by moving through them without letting denial wear a halo.

When the alley's light shifted - subtle, almost polite - Mara felt the system begin to prepare her next run. Not a blank reset. Not a neutral landing. A progression that carried consequence forward, with her corrective step written into the OS like a changed variable.

The air smelled briefly of clean rain and warm circuitry, and the alley's shadows receded just enough for her to see the route ahead - still dangerous, still scripted, but no longer stuck on the same bite.

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Bardo Dream OS Factory Reset

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